Tuesday, January 23, 2024
Magh 9, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaathwo Trayodashi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 38 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: AGENCY

India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi attending the opening of the grand temple of the Hindu god Lord Ram in Ayodhya, India on Monday.

PM: Stop extending project deadlines

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has called it necessary to stop extending projects' deadlines and increasing their costs.

Virtually inspecting the Sikta Irrigation Project and the third phase of the Mahakali Irrigation Project from the action room in the Prime Minister's Office on Monday, PM Prachanda said that extending deadlines and increasing financial burdens cast doubts on administrative intentions and impacted the country's economy.

"We must aim to complete all projects within the initial estimate and not increase their time and costs. Extending deadlines and expanding costs call our administrative intention and capacity into question and affect our economy and prosperity," he said.

The Prime Minister also said that the government would make arrangements to complete national pride and other major projects in time through the policies and programme and budget. "Lack of proper budget allocation has created a situation where both the quality of work and projects' progress are being affected. This appears to have contributed to delays and cost overrunning. We must end this malpractice now," he stressed.

Building on this point, he instructed project chiefs to deliver results. "We will solve policy and budgetary problems but you must work on the field. Do not extend deadlines and burden the nation."

The Prime Minister also directed them to change their working style and focus on development and public service. "Let us change our working style, let us be accountable," he plainly stated.

Also speaking on the occasion, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet hoped that improvements in the economy and clearing of contractors' dues would help projects gather momentum.

Meanwhile, Devraj Niroula, head of the Sikta project, said that lack of resources had affected the project's pace. Stating that Sikta would irrigate 42,766 hectares of land in Banke when completed, he said that the project needed funds to disburse compensation.

Niroula further informed that they would make a calendar to ensure they finish work within the stipulated deadline.

Expedite licence delivery process

In a separate joint discussion held on issues relating to driving licences, national identity cards and passports at the Prime Minister's Office in Singha Durbar the same day, PM Prachanda asked concerned bodies to expedite the delivery of driving licences to those who have passed the required exam.

Noting that 1.4 million people

» SEE PAGE 6

KATHMANDU RECORDS LOWEST TEMPERATURE OF THIS WINTER

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

The minimum temperature in the Kathmandu Valley dropped to 3.2 degrees Celsius on Monday, making the lowest recorded temperature till date this year.

Meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division, Saroj Pudasaini, said the temperature of the Kathmandu Valley was recorded 3.2 degrees Celsius today.

The visibility in Kathmandu Valley has also decreased and it was 3,000 meters.

With the decline in minimum temperature, Kathmandu folks have experienced chilling cold on Monday. Similarly, the Tarai area of the country is witnessing thick fog, affecting normal life there.

As per the weather data recorded on Sunday, Jumla recorded minus 5.6 degrees Celsius, Jomsom minus five degrees Celsius, and Jiri of Dolakha 1.0 degree Celsius.

There is a possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of high-hilly areas and mountainous areas of Koshi and Gandaki Provinces in the next 24 hours, according to the Division.

Cooperative operators duping public will be prosecuted: DPM Shrestha

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has said that it is necessary to make legal and institutional arrangements to control financial crimes.

Addressing the Crime Investigation Review Meeting organised by the Nepal Police Headquarters on Monday at the National Police Training Institute in Maharajgunj, DPM Shrestha said that necessary legal and institutional arrangements for the investigation of financial crimes will be managed by developing skilled manpower and brought into the framework of legal action.

"It is reported that the 'dealing' of billions is being done through crypto currency, illegal mode of financial transaction in Nepal, transactions of hundi and foreign currency are being made in new methods, a new trend has been seen in opening letters of credit (LC) to evade tax to the government," Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha said.

"All these new technological challenges have been created and seen as new problem in the national economy. Cryptocurrencies are being used in major crimes, the recent gold scandal has also revealed the use of crypto, it must be controlled at all cost," claimed DPM Shrestha.

Mentioning the need to prepare skilled manpower to investigate in cryptocurrency trading, he said that the government felt the lack of legal arrangements for this.

Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha said that financial crimes and frauds are increasing in the society as cooperatives deviate from their original purpose and aim and turn into financial institutions to earn more money in a short period of time.

He said that the government is preparing to create a law to control co-operative fraud soon.

"Cooperative and its operation modality should be redefined by amending the laws as cooperatives cannot be operated as institutions like commercial banks," said DPM Shrestha.

He said that the government has decided to establish a regulatory body, institute a deposit and credit guarantee fund and make the troubled cooperative management committee effective through the formation order of the Cabinet meeting.

Mentioning the findings from the initial investigation that the directors of the co-operatives have cheated the savers arbitrarily, he said that an investigation will be started soon on the transaction of such co-operatives.

Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha said that the process of taking action against cooperative operators involved in crime and fraud and giving justice to depositors has progressed.

"The government will give justice to depositors and cooperatives will be promoted as the backbone of the economy," he said.

Attorney General Dr. Din Mani Pokhrel said that in recent days, when the series of economic crimes has increased, a specialised structure should be created to investigate these related crimes. Few weeks ago, the Nepal Police Headquarters had also announced to establish separate financial crime investigation bureau under Nepal Police.

Pokhrel emphasised on the need to strengthen the system of investigation, prosecution and justice based on scientific, objective and reliable evidence.

Inspector General of Police Basanta Bahadur Kunwar said that the police have started homework for the establishment of a specialised bureau to investigate financial crimes.

IGP Kunwar revealed that rather than police investigating the victim's side, the criminals and their lobbying groups have their dominance and syndicate in fair crime investigation.

"Criminals have more knowledge about their rights than victims and crime investigators. And, they do have a syndicate in their favour," IGP Kunwar said.

Deputy Mayor of Kathmandu Metropolitan City, Sunita Dangol, said that the capacity of Nepal Police should be enhanced to meet the challenges created by digital crimes. She said that the KMC is going to provide training to develop skilled manpower related to cyber security under scholarship.

Silent period for NA polls comes into effect

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

The silent period for the National Assembly (NA) election has begun.

Issuing a notice, the Election Commission (EC) informed that the silent period for the elections commenced on Monday midnight.

The notice, issued on Monday, requests all election candidates, members of political parties and their sister organisations, and other individuals and entities who need to adhere to the electoral code of conduct to refrain from campaigning, organising discussions, interactions, meetings, conference, workshops and other events to solicit votes and circulate information in favour of or against a candidate or party through social networks, print, online or any other media. These prohibitions shall stay in effect until the conclusion of voting-related activities, the notice states.

Voting for the National Assembly is scheduled to take place from 9 am to 3 pm at designated voting centres on Thursday, January 25. Members of provincial assemblies and heads and deputy heads of local governments are eligible to cast their ballots in the election.

According to the list of voters approved by the EC on December 20, 2023, a total of 549 members of the provincial assemblies and 1, 498 chiefs and deputy chiefs of local levels are eligible voters in the election.

Similarly, the EC has confirmed the completion of all preparations for the election.

Altogether 51 candidates from eight political parties are in the fray for 19 seats in the Upper House of the Federal Parliament. The term of 20 of the 59 members of the NA is expiring this March and 19 of the positions will be filled via secret ballot while one will be filled through nomination by the President.

Leakages in advertising sector will be plugged: Minister Sharma



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that leakages in the advertising sector would be plugged.

Speaking at the 'Capacity Development of People Involved in Radio and Television Commercial Growth' programme organised by the Advertising Board, Minister Sharma said that due to the recent amendments in the advertising regulations, control over advertising irregularities would be reinforced.

Minister Sharma said although the government allocates a budget of billions for government advertising, the trend of significant budget allocation going only to a few media outlets had prompted the need for a regulatory system over the rules. She said, "Now the advertisement regulation has been amended. Its purpose is that all the funds allocated by the government would go to the media. If the advertisement comes through an agency, apart from the agency fee of 15 per cent, the remaining budget will go to the related media."

She said that almost all sectors in the country were suffering from economic crisis including advertisement and media. She said that many media were facing difficulties for their survival as media were not receiving the agreed budget for the advertisement.

Minister Sharma said that they were in process to issue National Advertisement Policy for making the overall advertising market healthy and transparent. She said the media which advocate for freedom of speech would be strong with well-managed advertisement markets.

She said, "We are actively seeking solutions on how to protect the media through laws and policies. It is imperative to provide training on media management and advertising market stakeholders. I have confidence that this training will be highly beneficial."

Construction of Highway in Koshi faces snag

BY HARI PRASAD KOIRALA
Urlabari, Jan. 22

The tree removal work on the Dharan-Kerabari-Letang-Madhumalla-Beldangi road section Shantinagar-Patapur and Barphalangphedi-Shantinagar road sections of the Madan Bhandari Highway has been hindered with a lack of coordination between the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport and the Ministry of Forests and Environment.

As part of the project construction, the majority of the 95.8-kilometre stretch of this road traverses through forested areas. Specifically, within the 53 kilometres of the Dharan-Kerabari-Letang-Madhumalla-Beldangi road section, there are 5,789 trees. The Shantinagar to Patapur road section, stretching 13.87 kilometres, has 3,689 trees, and the 13-kilometre stretch from Barphalangphedi to Shantinagar has 2,880 trees.

According to Subhash Kumar Datta, Information Officer of the Madan Bhandari Highway Project Damak office, the project submitted a request to the Ministry of Forest and Environment (MoFE) on March 23, 2023, seeking permission for the removal of trees.

Gopal Prasad Khakurel, head of the project, said that the work had been halted due to the MoFE's delay in tree removal.

Khakurel highlighted that the project faces a dual challenge of insufficient budget and a lack of interest from the MoEF in tree removal. He said that only Rs. 1.52 billion has been paid for the road, whereas the contracted amount was Rs. 4.6 billion.

Likewise, a contract was granted for the construction of the bridge on the road for Rs. 6.12 billion. The Koshi section of the Madan Bhandari Highway encompasses a total of 37 bridges. Currently, construction of 16 bridges has been completed, while construction is ongoing for the remaining 21 bridges.

While the work on the big bridges has been completed, the small bridges and culverts are under construction. Khakurel said that it seems that Rs. 4 billion should be paid when the work under construction is completed. Only Rs. 490 million was allocated for the project in fiscal year 2023/2024.

Out of this, a bill has been sent for the payment demand of Rs. 380 million. Looking at the details of the current work and progress, it seems that by the end of the current fiscal year, Rs. 1.45 billion should be given to the

» SEE PAGE 6

Biratnagar Ring Road Project in limbo

BY SASHIDHAR PARAJULI
Biratnagar, Jan. 22

The Federal government has withdrawn the Biratnagar Ring Road Project which was handed over to the local-level government five years ago.

The Ministry of Finance had decided to withdraw the project on December 4. However, the official letter regarding the decision has just arrived in the Ministry of Infrastructure Development of Koshi Province.

Koshi Province Assembly members have expressed dissatisfaction over the decision. Assembly member and former Minister Jeewan Acharya said that the project had remained in an abandoned situation for the past 26 years as both provincial and federal governments were trying to bring it under their respective control. The project has now become uncertain.

Meanwhile, the Provincial government was in full preparation to speed up the project which was handed to it by the federal government in 2018. It also demanded the federal government transfer the budget of Rs. 10 million which the federal government had allocated for the project in the current fiscal year. Ultimately, instead of providing the budget, the federal government had taken back the project.

Engineer Sushil Shrestha, head of the Infrastructure Development Office in Biratnagar, said, "We demanded the federal government to send the budget allocated for the project to the province. But now, it has taken back the project. Now, the project will be implemented by the federal government."

Two decades have passed since the construction of the 42-km ring road in Biratnagar began, but three kilometres of track is yet to be opened. Biratnagar Ring Road, whose foundation stone was laid by the then Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Bijay Kumar Gachhadar in 1997, has not been completed even 26 years after its construction began.

Revenue mobilisation govt priority: Finance Minister

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22



PHOTO/TRN
Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat inspecting Simraungad Customs Checkpoint in Santagunj, Bara on Monday.

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the government's goal is to increase revenue mobilisation and provide more facilities to the people. He made this remark while inspecting the Simraungad Customs Checkpoint in Santagunj of Suwarna Rural Municipality of Bara district Monday.

"We will gradually advance this checkpoint to meet the needs of the local people, and we will prepare the necessary infrastructure," he said. According to a press statement issued by his secretariat, Minister Mahat said that the role of the local municipality will be important in managing the Nepal-India border.

He said, "The government wants to make buying and selling easy in daily life. For this, we have to talk to the Indian side as well." Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that Bara district is important for food and manufacturing business.

He said that the government has prioritised the Nijgadh airport to upgrade the industrial corridor of Bara district. Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that if the airport is constructed, the importance of Bara will expand even more.

He said, "Most of the roads in Bara have been completed, after the construction of Sunkoshi Marin Diversion, there will be no problem for irrigation in Bara. Then the agricultural production of Bara will increase, as will industry, trade and business."

BULLION
(Rs. 10 Tolas)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 118,400
Worked Gold	: Rs. 117,850
Silver	: Rs. 1,390

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,098.69
Total Amount	: 6,366,070,003.35
No. of Share	: 18,043,244

Japanese carmaker sees long wait to reopen factories

AP
Tokyo, Jan.22

A Japanese automaker that cheated on safety tests for decades said Monday it doesn't expect to resume shipping cars any time soon. The Japanese government ordered a subsidiary of Toyota to halt production of its entire lineup after reports of faked safety test results emerged last year.

The Daihatsu Motor Co. skipped mandatory safety tests by copying data from testing on one side of cars to the other, and used timers to ensure airbags went off in tests, a review found. No major accidents have been reported in connection with the cheating, but the news has raised serious questions about oversight at Daihatsu, as well as its corporate parent Toyota.

Japanese regulators approved five of the company's models on Friday after more testing, but company leadership said factories will remain shuttered as it waits on suppliers. "We face a very tough road ahead in winning back customer trust about safety and security," corporate manager Keita Ide said Monday, stressing that customers felt betrayed. He said the company is working on a plan to prevent cheating in the future.

Daihatsu is known for kei cars, or light automobiles, including the popular Daihatsu Tanto "kei," or small, car. It also produces the Toyota Raize hybrid sport-utility vehicle, also sold as the Daihatsu Rocky.

An investigation including third-party experts found 174 cases of faked tests affecting dozens of models, including cars sold under the Toyota Motor Corp. nameplate.

The review found that cheating went back 30 years.

JetBlue and Spirit Airlines to appeal for blocked merger

AP
New York, Jan.21

JetBlue and Spirit are the nation's sixth- and seventh-largest carriers. JetBlue, which outbid Frontier Airlines, said it needed to acquire Spirit to compete more effectively against even bigger airlines.

JetBlue and Spirit Airlines said they will appeal a federal judge's ruling this week that blocked their plan to combine into a single carrier. The airlines said they filed a notice of appeal with the 1st U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals, following the terms of their agreement.

The Justice Department, which sued to block JetBlue's proposed $3.8 billion purchase of Spirit, declined to comment. JetBlue and Spirit are the nation's sixth- and seventh-largest carriers. JetBlue, which outbid Frontier Airlines, said it needed to acquire Spirit to compete more effectively against even bigger airlines.

But on Tuesday, a federal judge in Boston ruled that the deal violated antitrust law. The U.S. Justice Department had sued to stop the deal, arguing that consumers would be harmed and forced to pay higher fares if Spirit — the nation's biggest discount airline — were eliminated. The airlines announced their appeal in a statement that provided no other details.

Earlier Friday, Spirit said that a strong holiday-travel season in December boosted its fourth-quarter revenue. The Miramar, Florida-based airline also said that it is trying to refinance $1.1 billion in debt that is due for payment in September 2025.

Spirit also said that negotiations with Pratt & Whitney over engines that need to be reworked — resulting in the grounding of an average of 26 planes a day throughout 2024 — "have progressed considerably since October." The airline said it expects compensation that will provide "a significant source of liquidity over the next couple of years."

Spirit has been losing money since the start of 2020. Some analysts said it could face bankruptcy without the merger with JetBlue. The airlines announced their intention to appeal U.S. District Judge William Young's ruling after the stock market closed on Friday.

Shares of Spirit, which fell 62% over three days following the ruling, gained 17% in regular trading Friday, and rose another 13% in after-hours trading. JetBlue's shares fell 2% in extended trading.

Dadeldhura vegetables found pesticide safe

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dadeldhura, Jan. 22



No harmful pesticides were detected in the vegetables produced in Dadeldhura. The samples were collected from different markets of Dadeldhura and no harmful pesticides were found in the laboratory tests.

Khem Raj Paneru, Chief of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Dadeldhura, said that in the laboratory test conducted by the Central Agricultural Laboratory, Pesticide Residue Rapid Analysis Laboratory Unit, Attaria, Kailali, the amount of harmful pesticides for human health was not high in vegetables. According to him, fruit and vegetable samples such as cauliflower, tomato, banana were collected from different markets of Dadeldhura and examined.

According to the laboratory, the carbamate and organophosphate in pesticides used in vegetables affect human health. He said that its quantity was detected to be low in the samples of vegetables and fruits collected from Dadeldhura market. "If the amount of these elements is more than 35 per cent, it is poisonous, which means it will cause harm to health. But this was not seen in the tested vegetables," he said.

He said that in the report of the laboratory unit, in one sample of the examined cauliflower, carbamate 0.62 per cent and organophosphate 3.82 per cent was found while in another sample, carbamate 2.12 per cent, organophosphate 3.18 per cent, and in the third sample of cauliflower, carbamate 0.30 per cent and organophosphate 6.03 per cent was found.

Similarly, in one sample of tomato, carbamate 1.99 per cent, organophosphate 2.53 per cent, in the second sample, carbamate 9.55 per cent, organophosphate 16.41 per cent and in the third sample, carbamate 6.99 per cent, organophosphate 4.86 per cent was observed. He said that a report was received that fruits and vegetables are suitable for consumption as carbamate 7.59 per cent and organophosphate 5.07 per cent was found in banana samples.

The vegetables and fruits as samples have been collected from the market of Amargadhi Municipality-5 Bagbazar and Amargadhi Municipality-11, Sallaghari market, said Paneru. According to the laboratory report, it is mentioned that if these elements in vegetables are less than 35 per cent, they should be consumed, if 35 per cent, they should be kept for a few days and if they are above 45 per cent, they should be destroyed. In Dadeldhura, vegetables are being cultivated in 1,371 hectares of land.

According to Paneru, around 18.46 tonnes of vegetables are produced in the district yearly. Of the total production, around 10 per cent is being consumed in Dadeldhura and 90 per cent is being sent outside the district.

EU commits to support 16th Plan implementation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22



PHOTO/TRN
National Planning Commission's Vice-Chairman Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha and European Union's Ambassador Veronique Lorenzo in a meeting in Kathmandu.

Ambassador of the European Union Delegation to Nepal Veronique Lorenzo met with Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, Vice-Chairman of the National Planning Commission, Nepal. On Monday, Ambassador Lorenzo had a courtesy meeting with Vice-Chairman Shrestha at the commission office in Singha Durbar.

During the meeting, the issues of the 16th Plan being prepared by the Commission, the impact on trade of Nepal and the EU after upgrading Nepal from LDCs to developing countries, and the multi-sector nutrition programme were discussed, according to a press statement issued by the NPC.

The Vice-Chairman Shrestha thanked the EU for its support. Stating that the 16th Plan is being prepared by taking suggestions from all sectors, he said that the plan will be formulated so as to achieve the target.

The Vice-Chairman and EU Ambassador Lorenzo also discussed the impact on trade with the European Union and the measures to compensate for it. She said that the EU will help for the green economy and minimize infrastructure gap in Nepal.

Ambassador Lorenzo said that the EU prioritises cooperation and support for human capital (quality education) and the implementation of Nepal's good governance and federalism. She has expressed her commitment to support Nepal for the 16th plan as well as multi-sector nutrition programme.

In the context that Nepal is upgrading from a least developed country to a developing country in 2026, she also suggested that Nepal should do its homework to continue the facilities it is getting from the international community.

DAILEKH PETRO EXPLORATION REPORTS 80 % PROGRESS

RSS
Dailekh, Jan 22

Eighty percent work progress has been reported in a final survey for the exploration of petroleum products in Dailekh. This survey based in Bhirkhet, the project's main point, is said to be decisive for the exploration.

For the final survey, 45 ropanis of land (one ropani is equivalent to 5476 sq. ft.) at Bhirkhet of Bhairabhi Rural Municipality-1 has been acquired and land owners had been already provided with compensation. Twenty seven families received compensation for the acquired land (Rs 175,000 per ropani).

This survey is said to be significant in determining the volume of raw petroleum products and gas. According to the project chief for the Department of Mines and Geology, Dinesh Kumar Napit, studies so far suggest that Dailekh could be a major source for petro and gas.

The final drilling that will go underground up to four kilometres will be vital in determining the available volume of petro products. The drilling is assisted by a giant machine brought from China, according to him. The exploration is underway here since September-October, 2019.

It is jointly carried out by the Nepal Government, the Department and the China-based Geological Survey at the cost of Rs 2.40 billion.

Tourists prefer houses with thatched roofing

RSS
Muglin (Chitwan), Jan 22

Even in the hilly region of Chitwan, traditional houses with thatched roofs are rarely found in recent times. After the 'Gorkha earthquake' in 2015, most of the houses were constructed using zinc corrugated sheets. The hay-roofed traditional house of Tika Gurung, a local of Ichhakamana rural municiplaity-2, Mayatar, however was not damaged in the destructive earthquake. Gurung had planned to demolish the house and build a new one.

In the recent past, the house has become a tourists' preference so he switched off his mind and started repairing the house. With the expansion of the Fisling-Shaktikhor road, the house in Mayata has become the choice of the tourists.

Homeowner Gurung said, "I was thinking of building a new house by demolishing it, but with the increase in the number of tourists in Mayatar for the past few years with the expansion of the road, it has become the choice of tourists to take photos and stay in the 100-year-old roof house. According to him, the tourists coming here return only after taking photos at the house.

According to locals, this house with peculiar roofing is century-old. There has been a crowd of photographers taking snapshots of this house located on the north side of the blacktopped Fisling-Shaktikhor road.

The house maintaining originality has old-fashioned beehives. It has not been long since tourists started coming here. According to local Bhim Bahadur Praja, this was once the route of trekking from Gorkha, Dhading and other districts to India via Hetauda and Birgunj. But with the development of the road, Mayatar became unconnected after pedestrians stopped walking along the area.

After the construction of the Fisling-Shaktikhor rural road, the mobility of the people has increased in Mayatar. "I didn't think there would be so much mobility in this place, it's all because of the road, someday there are cars and bikes all over this courtyard," he said. "It is not only easy for the visitors, but the agricultural products of the locals here have also got access to market.

Ward Chair Pancha Bahadur Chepang said with the up-gradation of the Fisling-Shaktikhor road, the movement of tourists has increased and it has become easier for the locals to take agricultural produce to the market.

Some passengers going to Hetauda from Kathmandu use the Shaktikhor-Fisling road. Due to this, many vehicles have started plying through this road. This route can be reached from Fisling, Mauwakhola and Hugdikhola of Prithvi Highway through the old headquarters of Chitwan via Upardanggadhi, Shaktikhor and Tandi.

Lights installed to chase elephants away

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 22

The wards affected the most by wild elephants in Kamal Rural Municipality in Jhapa have begun installing lights on electric poles after the animals continued going berserk.

To mitigate the physical and human damages caused by elephants, a patrolling system, involving the formation of groups to deter elephants, has been implemented.

Hukum Singh Rai, Chairman of the rural municipality, said that lights have been installed on electric poles at the main entry points of the elephants.

After the elephants started destroying houses, consuming and damaging the stored paddy, and crushing crops in the fields, the affected individuals arrived at the rural municipality seeking assistance.

Elephants have been entering Ward Nos. 4 and 5, causing damage consistently. Rai said that the budget for the northern area of Guheshwari Tole in Ward No. 5 has been promptly allocated, and lights have been installed overnight. He said that without proper lighting, it would be challenging to guide the elephants to a secure location.

Similarly, after elephants caused distress to the locals by entering the vicinity around Jyoti Tole and Rijal's petrol pump in Ward No. 4 throughout the night, the municipality provided supplies such as sirens and flashlights.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
A wild elephant walking at light installed roads of Damak bazaar.

Rai said that he has been urging the initiation of necessary measures by convening a coordination meeting with relevant agencies to supply essential materials to those patrolling to frighten elephants.

In three weeks, elephants have caused damage to over a dozen houses in Kamal Rural Municipality.

Meanwhile, an elephant entered the premises of the Area Police of Damak on Monday morning.

A wild elephant that entered Damak market areas at 4:00 am on Monday wreaked havoc. When locals saw a mature wild elephant roaming in the main market area of Damak, they tried to chase it away. One local, Dinesh Adhikari, was injured in course of chasing the animal, and he was rushed to Nims Hospital.

When the people started chasing from all directions, the elephant entered the premises of the Area Police Office located in the heart of Damak.

According to chief of Damak Police Manoj Kumar Lama, the elephant gave a dash on its compound wall and entered the police office.

"But it caused no damage to the police office, and when the crowd got dispersed and the noise stopped, the elephant left the police office premises," Lama said.

Likewise, a herd of elephants caused damage to three houses in Kanepokhari, Morang, on Sunday night.

According to our Urlabari correspondent, the elephants partly destroyed the houses of Bishnu Kumari Jogi and Aita Bahadur Limbu of Shanti Chowk, in Kanepokhari-7. Similarly, in Chisangbasti of Ward No. 5 in Kanepokhari, the elephant pulled down a wall of an RCC house of Lati Urab, according to Assistant Sub-Inspector Gunaraj Pokharel.

Vice-chair of Kanepokhari Rural Municipality Rajamti Ingnam said that locals and police prevented the elephants from entering the human settlement by staying awake throughout the night.

Inedible colouring additive detected in cotton candy

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22



In a concerning revelation, it has come to light, that inedible colours, specifically Rhodamine B, have been detected in cotton candy, a beloved treat for children, which is openly being sold in Nepali streets.

> The Department of Food Technology and Quality Control, following a laboratory examination, has issued a public notice urging citizens to refrain from consuming cotton candy.

The Department of Food Technology and Quality Control, following a laboratory examination, has issued a public notice urging citizens to refrain from consuming cotton candy due to potential health risks.

The tainted cotton candy has infiltrated various outlets, including street boxes, markets, fairs, and other locations across different areas. The Department is actively discouraging the purchase and distribution of cotton candy.

Parents and guardians are emphatically advised not to allow their children to consume cotton candy until further notice. Additionally, the Department appeals to producers to avoid using non-edible dyes in the manufacturing of cotton candy, reinforcing the importance of adhering to food safety standards.

A stern warning has been issued that any production or sales found to violate this notice will be met with strict actions under the regulations outlined in the Food Act. The Department emphasizes its commitment to ensuring the safety of the public and underscores the seriousness of this matter, urging cooperation from all stakeholders to prevent any potential health hazards associated with the consumption of contaminated cotton candy.

NEWS BRIEF

Two die in road accident

Tanahun: Two persons were killed in a mini-truck accident in an inner road section in Devghat Rural Municipality-2 in Tanahun.

A truck with registration number Ga 1 Kha 4181 heading towards Chhipchhipe from Damauli met an accident after it fell off some 500 down the road on Saturday night, according to SP Abadesh Bista of the District Police Office, Tanahun.

In the accident, 65-year-old Nara Bahadur Gurung, of Devghat-3, and 45-year-old Bimaya Gurung, of the same ward, died.

Critically injured Gurung duo, who was receiving treatment in Damauli Hospital, was declared dead on Monday morning, said SP Bista. The driver of the mini truck was still at large, said police.

Tiger found dead in Kailali

Ghodaghodi: A Royal Bengal tiger was found dead at Amarawati Community Forest of Janaki Rural Municipality-9 in Kailali district on Sunday.

The female adult tiger was found tied with wire, said forester Ram Bahadur Rawal at the Sub-Division Office, Lamki.

Considering the malodour emanated from the lifeless big cat, its death is estimated to have occurred some days ago, the forester added.

The locals who had been in the forest to collect fodder had informed the police after spotting the dead tiger.

TRN

100,000 lamps lit in Myagdi to celebrate Ram Temple consecration



PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA \ TRN
Pilgrims gathering at Galeshwor Shivalaya on the banks of the Kaligandaki River at Galeshwordham, Myagdi on Monday to mark the consecration of Lord Ram in the newly built temple at Ayodhya, India.

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi (Beni), Jan. 22

The Galeshwor Shivalaya Area Development Trust and the Beni Municipality have lit 100,000 lamps (Lakhbatti) on the banks of the Kaligandaki River at Galeshwordham, Myagdi on Monday to mark the consecration of Lord Ram in the newly built temple at Ayodhya, India.

Last year, two Shaligram boulders were taken from the river for the Ayodhya temple. The part of the river they were taken from has been named Shree Ram Ghat. The 100,000 lamps were lit at the Ghat at the pre-determined auspicious time of 12.29 pm in the presence of Yogi Jagadguru Himalaya Baba.

A procession of pilgrims travelled from the Galeshwor Temple playing music and singing religious hymns and reached the Shree Ram Ghat to light the lamps.

On the occasion, Mayor of Beni Municipality Surat KC told The Rising Nepal that the local government planned to develop the Ghat as a destination for religious tourists. The area is already known as the entrance to the Hindu and Buddhist pilgrimage site of Muktinath.

"We plan to build infrastructure and develop the area as a religious destination," he said.

Meanwhile, Himalaya Baba said that the intention behind lighting the hundred thousand lamps was to establish Kaligandaki as a holy river and to inform devotees travelling to Kagbeni, Muktinath and Damodar Kunda of the virtues of bathing in it.

"Two boulders taken from this river have been placed in the sanctum sanctorum of the new Ram Temple," the Baba said, adding, "We intended to spread a message of religion and harmony by lighting the lamps here."

Week-long yoga camp concludes in Jumla

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jumla, Jan. 22

A week-long yoga camp organised on the occasion of the 9th National Yoga Day concluded in Jumla on Sunday. The yoga camp organised by the Ayurveda Health Centre Jumla in collaboration with the District Administration Office Jumla began on January 15. Participants expressed the importance of sustaining such initiatives.

Engaging in yoga from 8 am to 10 am daily, the participants highlighted the health benefits derived from the camp.

Raj Bahadur Mahat, president of Civil Society Jumla, stressed the significance of yoga in leading a healthy life, emphasising the pivotal roles of food, exercise, and social service. He underscored that yoga is not only a physical activity but a holistic approach to well-being.

Dr. Pratibha Sharma from Jumla Ayurveda Health Centre explained that regular yoga practice enhances energy flow in the body, promoting a sense of freshness. Acknowledging the interconnectedness of mental and physical health, she expressed gratitude to all participants for their dedication to the yoga camp.

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC)
Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal

Request for Expression of Interest

Name of Project : Financial Loan Management in NAC
First Date of Publication : 23 January 2024

1. NAC is requesting proposal from the eligible and qualified National and International Government Parties & Government Agencies, National & International Bank and Financial Institutions, International Lender Companies/Agencies licensed to provide loan, International Organizations/Agencies, and other Lender Companies ('Lender"), eligible for national and international financing for "***Financing as part of Financial Loan Management in Nepal Airlines Corporation".***
2. Interested eligible Lender may obtain further information and EOI document free of cost at the address mentioned below during office hours on or before 06 March 2024 or visit the client's website: ***https://www.nepalairlines.com.np/***
3. Expressions of interest shall be delivered to the address mentioned below on or before 07 March 2024 17:00 PM. The EOI Documents delivered after the due date and time shall not be entertained. If the last date of submission and opening falls on a government holiday then the next working day shall be considered the last day. The EOI shall be opened on 07 March 2024, 17:30 PM.
4. NAC reserves the right to select or reject any or all of Lender(s) without assigning any reasons whatsoever. NAC also reserves the right to entertain any government or government holding companies/agencies for participation in RFP in later stage too in addition to short listed parties.
5. Further information or clarification on the EOI documents can be obtained from the address below during office hours from 10:00 AM to 17:00 PM local time.

Finance Department
Nepal Airlines Corporation
Kantipath, Kathmandu. P.O. Box: 401
Tel No.: 00977-1-4227142, Fax: 977-1-4248621
Email: dir.fd@nac.com.np ddfpcca@nac.com.np

Doctor held with fake documents

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

Police have arrested a doctor on the charge of possessing a fake educational certificate and medical license number.

Acting upon a tip-off, the Valley Crime Investigation Office, Minbhawan arrested Sambuddha Bhattacharya, a resident of Biratnagar Metropolitan City-2 in Morang.

Speaking at a press conference organised on Monday at the office, Superintendent of Police (SP) and spokesperson for the Office, Rabindra Regmi said that Bhattacharya was arrested from Kathmandu after he was found to have a fake document stating that he was serving at the TU Teaching Hospital Maharajgunj and other medical centres in the Kathmandu Valley.

Bhattacharya was working at Dhaulagiri Himal Polyclinic in Basundhara and We Care Polyclinic in Naxal. He was found to have examined 42 patients in Dhaulagiri, claiming to be a thyroid doctor. According to the police, various government seals and Rs. 165,000 in cash were recovered from him.



PHOTO: TRN
Arrested fake doctor Sambuddha Bhattacharya.

Similarly, police inspector Nirmal Thapa, involved in the investigation, said that he was found to have checked 630 patients in We Care.

According to Inspector Thapa, Bhattacharya was charging Rs. 500 for checking a patient in Dhaulagiri. Similarly, his test fee in We Care was Rs. 750 per patient. The police have recovered seven stamps from the accused. Bhattacharya was found to be making fake letters of appreciation.

A letter of appreciation signed by former deputy prime minister Upendra Yadav, a letter of appreciation issued by WHO, and a lifetime membership card of the medical association were recovered from his house.

Inspector Thapa said that the documents were found to be fake when the recovered certificates were tested and verified. The police also recovered the letter of appreciation issued by Nepal Medicity Hospital in Lalitpur. It was also proved fake.

After his arrest, he told the police that he came to Nepal after studying medicine in China. However, he has not been able to show the doctor's certificate that he studied in China, inspector Thapa said.

His registration certificate issued by the Nepal Medical Council has also been confirmed to be fake.

SP Regmi said that further investigation would be conducted relating to drug-related offences and the tempering of official documents and letterheads.

विद्युत उत्पादन कम्पनी लिमिटेड
Vidhyut Utpadan Company Limited

Notice for Opening of Price Bids

(Date of publication: Jan 23, 2024)

This is to notify all concerned bidders that with reference to Technical bids opened on November 30, 2023 for the execution of ***Construction of Test Adit Tunnels of Mugu Karnali Storage Hydro Electric Project (MKHEP, 1902MW)*** at Piluchaur, Bajura (Contract No.VUCL/MKHEP-TAT/W/NCB/2080-081/01) as per Invitation for Bids published on **October 12, 2023** in "The Rising Nepal" National Daily and www.bolpatra.gov.np, following bidders have been selected as a ***Substantially Responsive Evaluated Bidders*** after evaluation of Technical Bids as per Instructions to Bidders and Evaluation & Qualification Criteria of Bidding Document.

Furthermore, all concerned bidders are hereby invited to attend the Price Bids Opening scheduled as follows.

S.N.	List of *Substantially Responsive Evaluated Bidders*	Price Bids Opening Date, Time & Place
1	***M/S B.P. Construction Pvt. Ltd.,*** Chhetrapur, Bharatpur-2,Chitwan	**January 30, 2024** at **13:00 Hrs at VUCL's Office , Buddhanagar, Kathmandu**
2	***M/S Pabita- Paradise JV (Lead: Paradise Builders Pvt. Ltd., Sub: Pabita Nirman Sewa),*** Jwagal, Lalitpur -10	
3	***M/S Sherpa Hydro Construction Pvt. Ltd*** , Boudha, Kathmandu	
4	***M/S High Himalaya Hydro Construction Pvt. Ltd.,*** Dhobighat, Lalitpur-3	
5	***M/S Bavari Construction Pvt. Ltd.,*** Chandol, Dhumbarahi, Kathmandu-4	

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Come, gentlemen, I hope we shall drink down all unkindness.
-- William Shakespeare

EDITORIAL

Need For Trade Spur

The latest trade data made public by the Department of Customs show that Nepal's export has declined by 7.23 per cent while the import has fallen by 3.09 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year compared to the same period of last fiscal year 2022/23. Despite this, economists have argued that the economy is back on track. The reduction in the export of major exportable goods, including soybean oil and palm oil, resulted in decline in the overall export during the review period.

Owing to declines in export as well as import, there was some improvement in the overall trade deficit situation during the period. Another notable thing about this is the massive growth in the import of electric vehicles over that period. About 6,000 electric vehicles, including cars, jeeps, vans, buses and trucks worth Rs. 14 billion have been imported during the period, with electric three-wheelers accounting for Rs. 510 million. The figure also shows that the export of cement and clinker to India has increased significantly during that period, rising to Rs. 1.76 billion from Rs. 86 million.

The southern neighbour is currently the world's fastest growing major economy, and the mammoth spending on infrastructure building is driving much of that growth. This means India is consuming a large quantity of cement to power its construction frenzy. Nepal has arrived at a position to benefit from India's rise. How? Our tremendous growth in the cement manufacturing factories means that we are in a position to supply the cement that India needs. The government should incentivise them towards that goal which is not only feasible but also a necessity if we are to improve our economic standing.

Decline in both exports and imports have contributed to a fall in foreign trade during the period. Though the country's foreign trade has decreased significantly, the growth of electric vehicles in popularity is a positive trend and comes at a time when we are producing more and more hydro-electricity needed to recharge and drive them. They are far better options on environmental and health grounds compared with their fossil-fuel powered cousins. They also hold promise to reduce the use of both fossil fuels as well as vehicles they power – the import of which is a drain on our foreign exchange reserves.

The country faces a trade deficit of Rs. 693.19 billion. It is 2.62 per cent less than the same period last year. Our export of hydropower has contributed to make this happen. To lower the trade deficit further, prioritising the export of cement can be a good option. And there is no denying the fact that such industries have grown to become our strengths in recent years with far more capacity to export it than we are doing it currently.

While a reduction in the trade deficit is considered positive, the decrease may be due to decline in consumers' purchasing power. It can also mean that people are getting poorer because of diminishing income. There is also a widespread concern that the economy is generating fewer good-paying jobs than needed to lift many out of poverty or to pay enough to lead a decent life. It is desirable on the part of the government to take this matter seriously and take necessary measures.

Women Fight Femicide

KHADIDJA KELALECH

In Algeria, patriarchy is still deeply rooted. Women are legally and socially disadvantaged, and the number of femicides has been alarming for years. Many women stand up against violence and oppression. The 1984 Algerian Family Code governs crucial aspects of marriage, divorce and inheritance. Women's rights are restricted as most decisions require the consent of men. Despite amendments in 2005 and 2016 aimed at bolstering women's agency in matters of marriage and divorce, gender equality gaps persist. Notably, gender-based violence issues like domestic abuse and marital rape remain largely unaddressed.

In recent years, men have murdered numerous women because of their gender, referred to as femicides. Activists of the Féminicides Algérie platform are committed to documenting these crimes. Between 2019 and 2021, they registered 187 cases, two of which attracted significant attention.

In October 2020, the tragic story of Chaïma, a 19-year-old from Algiers' outskirts, shook the nation. She was lured to an abandoned petrol station by a man who sought revenge because she had sent him to prison for a previous rape. Chaïma faced horrifying brutality. The culprit raped and tortured her and ultimately set her on fire.

This crime prompted widespread protests across Algerian cities. Women demanded an end to gender-based violence and justice for Chaïma. Activists used hashtags like #JeSuisChaïma, #WeLostOneOfUs and #NousSommesToujoursLà to draw attention to the issue. Disappointingly, some parts of social media chose to blame the victim's style of dress rather than holding her rapist and killer accountable for the crime.

Another prominent case is that of 39-year-old journalist Tinhinane Laceb. The mother of two daughters hosted an environmental programme on Algerian television. On 26 January 2021, she was murdered by her husband who was very jealous and could not accept that she was having a career. Algerian television initially reported this act as a mere "death" failing to specify it as a femicide or assassination.

Algerian women increasingly refuse to accept gender-specific violence. However, the prevailing culture of silence and stigmatisation makes it difficult for victims to seek justice. Although laws exist against gender-based violence in Algeria, they are often not sufficiently enforced. 23-year-old Dhoha vividly describes how Algerian women are facing gender-based violence as double victims, burdened not only by their attackers but also by societal scepticism: "You will be afraid of getting attacked and also afraid that people won't believe you. Afraid of the attacker and society. Who will believe me?"

Algerian women have actively embraced advocacy and resistance movements. Social media has emerged as a potent tool for amplifying their voices and spotlighting issues long shrouded in secrecy. For instance, in response to Chaïma's tragic murder, the Association des Actrices Algériennes (Association of Algerian Actresses) released a YouTube video featuring renowned Algerian actresses. This video is a satirical critique of patriarchal and misogynistic values, aimed to challenge the oppression of women. It met with patriarchal backlash, accumulating numerous dislikes as many Algerians found it offensive to the country's religious and traditional values.

However, this has not stopped Algerian women from resisting and fighting for legislative reform and cultural change.

-- Development and Cooperation

Shifting Tides In Global Order



Keshav Bhattarai



Mahmoud Yousef

Amidst the intricate tapestry of global relations, the United States, once the uncontested leader, faces internal challenges jeopardising its global standing. The evolving global order is shaped by diverse factors, including geopolitical conflicts, technological advancements, and strategic resource competition. This article examines the multifaceted challenges confronting the U.S. and discusses how these issues may trigger a significant shift in the global balance of power.

China and Russia's involvement in the Middle East and North Africa, particularly with regard to Iran, the Gaza War, and Houthi actions in Yemen, has the potential to reshape the global order. The interconnected events highlight a complex geopolitical landscape. Houthi rebels in Yemen play a key role, challenging Saudi forces and influencing regions beyond Yemen, impacting the Horn of Africa, Egypt, the Suez Canal, and neighboring countries' security. The conflict has international dimensions, linking to the Yemen crisis and Red Sea activities. The Israel-Palestine dispute is increasingly seen as a global South versus West confrontation. Global attention has shifted from the Gaza War to Ukraine war and vice-versa, reflecting evolving priorities in global geopolitics involving Iran, Israel, the United States, and Turkey.

Spillover of Russo-Ukraine conflict

A key factor contributing to the transformation of the global order is the ongoing geopolitical landscape marked by conflicts like the Russo-Ukraine war and tensions in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA). China and Russia's active involvement in these regions adds complexity to the situation. As the U.S. grapples with internal divisions and concerns about election integrity, its ability to maintain international leadership is questioned. The Biden administration, facing challenges in providing military support to Ukraine, is compelled to reassess its priorities amid escalating tensions between Israel and Hamas since October 07, 2023.

In the MENA region, tensions between Israel, Hamas, and Hezbollah, supported by Iran and discreetly backed by China and Russia, are a significant focal point. This situation has implications for the global standing of the United States. The complex dynamics of the Israel-Palestine conflict, the U.S.'s support to Netanyahu, and the distant possibility of a two-state solution present challenges for Biden's reelection efforts. Israel's military advantage and Hezbollah's designation as a terrorist organisation add further complexity, shaping the future global order in unpredictable ways.

The Russo-Ukraine conflict and developments in BRICS nations are reshaping the global order. Russia's military actions lead to isolation and economic repercussions. Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) adoption has transformative potential but raises governance concerns, particularly with China and Russia in the MENA region. Amid technological challenges, mineral shortages, and protectionist measures, the U.S.-China high-tech rivalry intensifies, potentially weakening the U.S.- China's collaboration on AI with the U.S. doesn't diminish its dominance in critical minerals and post-carbon energy tech, aiming to make U.S. resource access more expensive. The global shift to post-carbon alternatives introduces complexities and elevates costs. The U.S. responds by securing semiconductor capabilities and imposing export controls to maintain a technological advantage.

> South Africa has unexpectedly taken Israel to The Hague on genocide charges, adding a global legal dimension to the conflict.

The mass evacuation of civilians in Gaza amid the Israel-Palestine conflict, coupled with Israel's disavowal of permanent occupation, raises legal concerns. Evacuation methods are deemed impractical, potentially sparking a broader legal dispute. Geopolitical factors may impact alliances and international relations. The forceful eviction, lacking viable alternatives, raises human rights concerns and invokes the Genocide Convention. Israeli officials' dehumanising language adds complexity to human rights discourse. Historical elements like colonisation, apartheid, occupation, and the Gaza siege require a nuanced understanding.

South Africa has unexpectedly taken Israel to The Hague on genocide charges, adding a global legal dimension to the conflict. This move, reminiscent of South Africa's history, provides a broader perspective on the situation. The International Court of Justice (ICJ) is crucial in addressing human rights violations, showcasing global interest in justice. While lacking direct enforcement, provisional measures could influence public opinion and governments. Political dynamics in South Africa may impact the case, highlighting the interplay of legal and political factors. This internationalises the Israel-Palestine conflict, with potential outcomes ranging from an ICJ-ordered ceasefire to case dismissal.

Meanwhile, the potential change in Iran's leadership, given Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's declining health and the Iranian Revolutionary Guards Corps' (IRGC) rising influence, repeated bombing in public gatherings, could signify a significant shift in domestic and foreign policies. Military involvement in leadership may introduce complexities domestically and internationally, impacting Iran's alliances and altering power dynamics. The evolving situation calls for careful consideration of interconnected factors, with the IRGC's potential different priorities and strategies compared to a purely political leadership. This probable shift may have repercussions on regional ambitions and alliances, requiring the international community to assess and adapt to potential changes in Iran's leadership.

Legal disputes

In the context of the changing global order in the MENA region, a leadership shift towards military influence may introduce uncertainties and reshape geopolitical dynamics. The region has already witnessed instabilities in Iraq and Libya after throwing the seasoned long-term autocratic leaders. Monitoring these developments closely and considering broader implications on international relations is crucial.

The Israel-Palestine conflict, involving legal disputes at the ICJ and South Africa's involvement, could influence the global order through legal processes, international alliances, and diverse perspectives. The outcome may shape how the world perceives and addresses the conflict, as well as human rights violations by Western allies. Amidst geopolitical conflicts, the U.S. faces challenges in maintaining international leadership, potentially leading to a reshaping of the global order. The interaction of political, technological, and economic factors adds uncertainty to the emergence of a new world order, challenging the existing global leader. Upholding democratic norms and values, leveraging its military strength, strong economy, natural resources, and strategic geographical location, the U.S. can potentially maintain global leadership.

(Bhattarai (bhattarai@ucmo.edu) is a Professor of Geography and Yousef (yousef@ucmo.edu) is a Professor of Computer Science and Cyber Security at the University of Central Missouri, USA.)

NAM's Relevance And Nepal's Stance



Narayan Upadhyay

With the end of the 19th Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) summit in Uganda on Friday, many have raised questions about the movement's significance in today's multi-polar world. According to observers, while the NAM was founded to promote non-interference, respect for sovereignty, and peaceful coexistence, some of its founding members have strayed from its core doctrine. Many of the organisation's member states, the second biggest after the United Nations, have drifted towards the arcs of certain powers or military blocs, sparking controversy about the organisation's relevancy.

The idea of the movement took shape in April 1955 when the leaders of 25 African-Asian countries met in the city of Bangdung, Indonesia, and it formally began in 1961 with the first summit in Belgrade, with the goal of establishing a common platform of developing countries that believe in mutual respect and cooperation. Key world leaders of that period — Jawaharlal Nehru, Prime Minister of India; Gamal Abdel Nasser, President of Egypt; Joseph Broz Tito, President of Yugoslavia; Indonesian PM Sukarno; Ghana's President Kwame Wrumah and then-King Mahendra of Nepal — all played important roles in the movement's formation.

Neutrality

These leaders sought to keep their nations neutral and desired to live in peace in the face of escalating enmity between the two superpowers of the time — the United States and the Soviet Union — both of whom were involved in the Cold War following the end of World War II. They founded NAM and avoided aligning with either of these two powers. Countries that supported either of these two countries took part in the NATO and Warsaw Pact blocs.

Political analysts describe NAM as a non-violent pressure organisation that adheres to the Panchsheel Principle of non-interference, respect for sovereignty, openness, mutual collaboration, and peaceful coexistence. However, many member nations, mostly poor, undeveloped, or developing at the time of its creation, have turned a new leaf as many have achieved growth and economic well-being, forcing them to reconsider their global standing in light of the changing international order. Some of them felt compelled to side with specific blocs.

For example, India, a crucial founding member, has emerged as an economic and military force, attracting attention to the Western force arc. Because of geopolitics and its conflict with China, the world's second-greatest economic and military superpower, India has felt a compulsion to align itself with the Western bloc in order to preserve a power balance. In the South Asian area, however, India is criticised for playing a big brother's role. It has fought multiple wars against Pakistan, even after the foundation of NAM. However, the world has come a long way since the organisation's inaugural summit in 1961. The Soviet Union dissolved in 1989, and some communist republics in Europe that survived under the Soviet Union have since joined NATO, headed by the USA and Western Europe.

China has emerged as an economic and military giant, holding sway throughout the world as a result of its economic might. The country's economic prowess and footprint can be seen in numerous nations across Asia, Africa, the Americas, and Europe. Despite the fact that NAM meetings are conducted every year with the goal of fostering peace and prosperity, wars continue to break out in various regions of the world. The current confrontations between Russia and Ukraine, as well as Israel and Hamas, have rendered the Panchasheel concept difficult to follow. Frictions of many types between and among nations have become an embarrassment for NAM doctrines.

> Non-alignment remains a cornerstone of Nepal's foreign policy, allowing the country to establish its independence and pursue a significant presence in the global arena.

Amid skepticism about the NAM's relevance, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, who addressed the NAM Summit, emphasised sovereign equality, mutual respect, and peaceful dispute resolution. The PM's speech focused on world peace, climate change, and the crippling effects of the COVID-19 pandemic. He stated that Nepal would stay dedicated to the NAM's ideals and aspirations since his country's constitution favours the Movement's principles as well as the United Nations charter, conforms to international law, and recognises global peace. He claimed that the movement has the potential to play a critical role in restructuring the global financial architecture and called on rich nations to fulfil their financial commitments to assist countries in unfavourable situations in achieving their development goals.

Despite being marred by internal conflicts and pressures from powerful nations, Nepal, as a founding member, has actively participated in all NAM forums, demonstrating its dedication to the cause and its unwavering efforts to achieve world peace, global economic success, and national freedom. In the meantime, it is heartening to note that Nepal's foreign policy is consistent with the NAM's values, stressing non-alignment, neutrality, and universal equality as critical aspects of a nation's geopolitical concerns. Nepal's commitment to the movement remains strong, providing the country with a diplomatic strategy for navigating the complexity of world politics.

Viable platform

The small South Asian nation continues to contribute to NAM's goals, which include addressing current issues and promoting a global order based on peace, collaboration, and mutual respect. While some may question the NAM's importance, non-alignment remains a cornerstone of Nepal's foreign policy, allowing the country to establish its independence and pursue a significant presence in the global arena. The NAM, which was originally intended to contribute to economic growth and international peace, has in recent years grown into a platform for advocating for poor nations' independence and development, which is beneficial for nations like Nepal and others.

Although the movement's key success lies in the fact that it has the potential to be a major platform after the United Nations, with participation from governments all around the world, it often confronts difficulties in remaining relevancy in today's world as the global power hierarchy is shifting. Meanwhile, Nepal's geopolitics have been a source of worry in terms of maintaining a neutral posture, as various economic powers have competed for a bigger foothold in this tiny Himalayan nation. The function and relevance of the NAM, together with the United Nations, are, therefore, advantageous to Nepal and other countries dealing with powerful neighbours and nations.

(The author is former managing editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 23, 1974

"Life's Dream Realised"

Kathmandu, Jan, 22: "My life's' dream to see the Himalayas has been realised," reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Promote Export-oriented industry

This refers to news report '*Exports down by 7% in first six months*' published in your daily on Monday. According to report, the country's export has declined by 7.23 per cent while the import decreased by 3.09 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year compared to the same period of last fiscal year 2022/23.

The export of major exportable goods, including soybean oil and palm oil declined. Other export items are sunflower oil, tea, coffee, ginger, yarchagumba and fruits juice. The good news is that export of cement and clinker has increased significantly during the review period.

The foreign trade has naturally gone down with the decrease in both exports and imports. The trade deficit stands at Rs 693.19 billion which 2.62 per cent less



than the same period last year. This is because of the decline in the import.

The fall in the export should be taken seriously by the concerned authorities and steps need to be taken to promote the export-oriented industries.

Rahul Lama
Janakpur

TAILPIECE

After church, little Johnny and his brother go ice fishing. Little Johnny starts drilling on the ice when a voice from above says, "Young man, there's no fish down there." Little Johnny asks his brother, "Who is that?" His brother replies, "I don't know."

So little Johnny starts to drill again and the voice says again, "For the second time, there's no fish down there. "Little Johnny asks his brother, "Could that be God? "His brother replies again, "I don't know." Little Johnny starts drilling again and the voice says once more, "Young man, for the last time, I'm telling you there's no fish down there.

"Johnny looks up and asks, "Is that you, God?" The voice says, "No, I'm the manager and the rink's closed."-

Cameroon starts first malaria vaccine scheme for children

AP
Combewa, Cameroon, Jan. 22



PHOTO: AP

A mother holds her baby receiving a new malaria vaccine as part of a trial at the Walter Reed Project Research Centre in Kombewa in Western Kenya on Oct. 30, 2009.

Cameroon will be the first country to routinely give children a new malaria vaccine as the shots are rolled out in Africa.

The campaign due to start Monday was described by officials as a milestone in the decades-long effort to curb the mosquito-spread disease on the continent, which accounts for 95% of the world's malaria deaths.

"The vaccination will save lives. It will provide major relief to families and the country's health system," said Aurelia Nguyen, chief program officer at the Gavi vaccines alliance, which is helping Cameroon secure the shots.

The Central Africa nation hopes to vaccinate about 250,000 children this year and next year. Gavi said it is working with 20 other African countries to help them get the vaccine and that those countries will hopefully immunize more than 6 million children through 2025.

Cameroon will be the first country to routinely give children a new malaria vaccine as the shots are rolled out in Africa.

In Africa, there are about 250 million cases of the parasitic disease each year, including 600,000 deaths, mostly in young children.

Cameroon will use the first of two recently approved malaria vaccines, known as Mosquirix.

The World Health Organization endorsed the vaccine two years ago, acknowledging that that even though it is imperfect, its use would still dramatically reduce severe infections and hospitalizations.

The GlaxoSmithKline-produced shot is only about 30% effective, requires four doses and protection begins to fade after several months. The vaccine was tested in Africa and used in pilot programs in three countries.

GSK has said it can only produce about 15 million doses of Mosquirix a year and some experts believe a second malaria vaccine developed by Oxford University and approved by WHO in October might be a more practical solution.

That vaccine is cheaper, requires three doses and India's Serum Institute said they could make up to 200 million doses a year.

Gavi's Nguyen said they hoped there might be enough of the Oxford vaccines available to begin immunizing people later this year.

Neither of the malaria vaccines stop transmission, so other tools like bed nets and insecticidal spraying will still be critical. The malaria parasite mostly spreads to people via infected mosquitoes and can cause symptoms including fever, headaches and chills.

Trump may testify in sex abuse defamation trial

AP
New York, Jan. 22



PHOTO: AP

Former U.S. President Donald Trump attends the closing arguments in the Trump Organisation civil fraud trial in the Manhattan borough of New York, Jan. 11, 2024.

Former President Donald Trump has told the public for years what he thinks of E. Jean Carroll, the writer who claims he sexually assaulted her in the 1990s. Now he has a chance to talk to a jury about her — but within limits he might well test.

Trump could testify as soon as Monday in the defamation trial over his 2019 comments branding Carroll a liar who faked a sexual attack to sell a memoir.

He plans to be in court as the New York trial resumes after a weekend break.

Because a different jury found last year that Trump sexually abused Carroll, U.S. District Judge Judge Lewis A. Kaplan has ruled that if the former president takes the stand now, he won't be allowed to say she concocted her allegation or that she was motivated by financial or political considerations.

But even while just watching the proceedings, the voluble ex-president and current Republican front-runner hasn't checked his contempt for the case.

While Carroll testified last week, he complained to his lawyers about a "witch hunt" and a "con job" loudly enough so that the judge threatened to throw Trump out of the courtroom if he kept it up. Trump piped down and stayed in court, then held a news conference where he deplored the "nasty judge."

"It's a disgrace, frankly, what's happening," Trump told reporters, repeating his claim that Carroll's allegation was "a made-up, fabricated story."

Besides tangling with Kaplan, Trump bucked the New York state judge in his recent civil business fraud trial involving claims that he inflated his wealth.

Trump, who denies any wrongdoing, delivered a brief closing argument of sorts without committing to rules for summations and assailed the judge from the witness stand. He also was fined a total of $15,000 for what the judge deemed violations of a gag order concerning comments about court staffers.

Trump's attorneys are appealing the order.

Blinken to start West Africa tour to boost democracies

AFP
Washington, Jan. 22



PHOTO: AFP

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken waves as he boards his plane at Andrews Air Force Base in Maryland on January 21, 2024.

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken on Monday opens a weeklong tour of Africa's west coast as he seeks to bolster US-friendly democracies with security deteriorating in the Sahel.

The top US diplomat will start in Cape Verde before visiting Ivory Coast, Nigeria and Angola, his first trip to sub-Saharan Africa in 10 months as he takes a break from a time-consuming focus on the Israel-Hamas war.

With many Africans uneasy about the US attention to the Middle East and Ukraine, and President Joe Biden failing to live up to a promise to visit the continent in 2023, Blinken will seek to show a softer side of the United States on the trip.

The football-loving, French-speaking American is expected Monday evening at an African Cup of Nations match in Abidjan, days after a visit to Ivory Coast by the foreign minister of China, which Washington sees as its top long-term rival and has ramped up influence in Africa over the past two decades.

On his last trip to the region in March 2023, Blinken became the top US official ever to visit Niger, hoping to show support for elected president Mohamed Bazoum.

Four months later, Niger's military toppled Bazoum, and last week the coup-installed prime minister was visiting Moscow to seek greater cooperation.

The base, and US troops, remain in Niger but Washington has been looking at options in more stable coastal countries as hopes dim for restoring the democratic government in Niger, whose coup leader expelled forces of former colonial power France, a US ally.

General James Hecker, the US Air Force commander for both Europe and Africa, said late last year that "several locations" elsewhere in West Africa were being discussed for a new drone base.

Molly Phee, the top US diplomat for Africa, said Blinken will look to assist countries "on all fronts to strengthen their societies, to prevent the expansion of the terrorist threat we see in the Sahel".

He will encourage countries to prioritise "the security of civilians when you're undertaking military operations, and to promote human rights and community development, particularly in marginalised populations," she told reporters.

She said Blinken will praise the democratic consolidation in Ivory Coast under President Alassane Ouattara, a US-educated economist who has sought to turn a page on a decade of civil conflict since he was first elected in 2010.

Ivory Coast has not witnessed a major terrorist attack for some two years.

UN panel to grill Russia on fate of thousands of 'evacuated' children

AFP
Moscow, Jan. 22

Moscow will be asked to explain at the UN on Monday what has happened to thousands of Ukrainian children believed to have been forcibly sent to Russia since its 2022 invasion.

The United Nations Committee on the Rights of the Child -- 18 independent experts -- is set to examine Russia's record over two days, as part of a regular review.

Their lengthy list of concerns was sent to Moscow in the first half of 2023.

They want to know how many children have been "evacuated" to Russia or within Russian-occupied parts of Ukraine.

They also want to know what Moscow has done to protect "the right of such children to preserve their identity, including nationality, name and family relations".

Kyiv estimates 20,000 Ukrainian children have been forcibly deported to Russia.

Moscow says it wants to protect these children from the fighting. Russia launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022.

Only around 400 children have so far been repatriated.

"Placements for evacuated children are arranged, first and foremost, at their request and with their consent," Russia said in a written response sent in October and shown to media by the UN on Friday.

It does not specify the total number of children affected, but said they "included children from national residential institutions for orphans and children without parental care (about 2,000 in total)" and children with Ukrainian citizenship. It also said that between April 1, 2022 and June 31, 2023, some 46,886 Ukrainian children acquired Russian citizenship.

Kateryna Rashevska, a legal expert with the Regional Center for Human Rights, a Ukrainian NGO, hopes the committee will call for an "international legal mechanism" to identify and return the children home.

"Now, the process of returning Ukrainian children is only a very sporadic process", she told AFP.

At the current rate, "we need another 90 years in order to repatriate only already-identified Ukrainian children", she said, urging the UN General Assembly in New York to adopt a resolution creating an international mechanism.

PRISM

6-legged spaniel undergoes surgery

London: A spaniel born with six legs that was found abandoned in a supermarket parking lot is now like other dogs after having her extra limbs surgically removed.

Ariel, who was named for "The Little Mermaid" character because the additional appendage with two paws on the end looked like a flipper, ran through the grass outside a veterinary hospital Saturday as she adjusted to life on four legs.

"She is doing brilliantly," said Vicki Black, director of the Langford Vets Small Animal Referral Hospital, where she was operated on Thursday.

The dog, who had multiple birth defects, was found in the center of Pembroke, Wales, in September. Greenacres Rescue took her in and raised funds for her surgery.

Fish blamed for mysterious sound

Florida: A Florida scientist said a mysterious bass sound reported by residents in the Tampa Bay area might be coming from mating fish.

Area residents reported hearing the low-pitched sound periodically since 2021, and so far no concrete answers have been found as to its origins.

James Locascio, a senior scientist with the Mote Marine Laboratory and Aquarium, said the sound could be coming from black drum fish in the bay. He said the fish produce throbbing sounds during their mating season when muscles vibrate against their swim bladders.

He said the sound could reach as far as a mile away from the water.

(AP)

Millions celebrate temple opening in India

AP
Ayodhya, India, Jan. 22



PHOTO: AP

Bollywood actor Amitabh Bachchan, centre left with his son Abisheik Bachchan, centre right along with other chief guests sit awaiting the opening of a temple dedicated to Hindu deity Lord Ram, in Ayodhya, India, Monday, Jan.22, 2024.

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday opened a Hindu temple built on the ruins of a historic in the northern city of Ayodhya, in a political triumph for the populist leader.

The temple is dedicated to Hinduism's Lord Ram and fulfils a long-standing demand by millions of Hindus who worship the revered deity and extoll him for the virtues of truth, sacrifice and ethical governance.

Modi and his governing Bharatiya Janata Party hope that opening the temple will help catapult the prime minister to a record third successive term in elections expected this spring. But with the temple still under construction, critics accuse Modi of a hurried opening to woo voters.

Modi, dressed in a traditional kurta tunic, led the opening ceremony as Hindu priests chanted hymns inside the temple's inner sanctum, where a 1.3-metre (4.3-foot) stone sculpture of Lord Ram was installed last week. A conch was blown by a priest to mark the temple's opening and Modi placed a lotus flower in front of the black stone idol, decked in intricate gold ornaments and holding a golden bow and arrow. He later prostrated before the idol.

Nearly 7,500 people, including elite industrialists, politicians and movie stars, witnessed the ritual on a giant screen outside the temple as a military helicopter showered flower petals.

"Our Lord Ram has arrived after centuries of wait," Modi said in a speech after the ceremony, receiving a resounding applause from thousands of attendees. He said the temple was built after "countless sacrifices" and is testament to a rising India "breaking the shackles of slave mentality." "Jan. 22, 2024, is not merely a date but marks the dawn of a new era," Modi said.

Modi's government turned the event into a national occasion by organising live screenings across the country and closing offices for half a day. Saffron flags — the colour of Hinduism — adorned the streets of various cities where government party workers had gone door to door handing out religious pamphlets.

Television news channels ran nonstop coverage of the event, portrayed as a religious spectacle. Some movie theatres broadcast the event live with complimentary popcorn. Many states declared the day a public holiday. In a rare step, stock and money markets were closed for the day.

"Ram Rajya (rule) begins," a TV news headline said. Ram Rajya is a Sankrit phrase that means just and ethical governance in Hinduism but has also been used by Hindu nationalists to signify Hindu domination in an officially secular India.

Modi has been the face of an unprecedented and unapologetic fusion of religion and politics in India. Ahead of the temple opening, he set the tone by visiting numerous Ram temples over 11 days as part of a Hindu ritual.

Analysts and critics see Monday's ceremony as the start of the election campaign for Modi, an avowed Hindu nationalist and one of India's most consequential leaders. They say the pomp-filled display led by the government shows the extent to which the line between religion and state has eroded under Modi.

"Prime ministers prior to Modi have also been to temples, been to other places of worship, but they went there as devotees. This is the first time that he went there as somebody who performed the ritual," said Nilanjan Mukhopadhyay, an expert in Hindu nationalism and author of a book on Modi.

The temple, located at one of India's most vexed religious sites, is expected to embolden Modi's chances of returning to power by drawing on the religious sentiments of Hindus, who make up 80% of India's population of 1.4 billion.

Ayodhya, once crowded with tightly packed houses and rundown stalls, has undergone an elaborate makeover in the lead up to the temple's inauguration. Narrow roads have been turned into a four-lane pilgrimage route leading to the temple, tourists are arriving at a new airport and sprawling railway station, and major hotel chains are building new properties.

TODAY IN HISTORY

393 – Roman emperor Theodosius I proclaims his eight-year-old son Honorius co-emperor.
1571 – The Royal Exchange opens in London.
1579 – The Union of Utrecht forms a Protestant republic in the Netherlands.
1656 – Blaise Pascal publishes the first of his Lettres provinciales.
1719 – The Principality of Liechtenstein is created within the Holy Roman Empire.
1795 – After an extraordinary charge across the frozen Zuiderzee, the French cavalry captured 14 Dutch ships and 850 guns, in a rare occurrence of a battle between ships and cavalry.
1846 – Slavery in Tunisia is abolished.
1849 – Elizabeth Blackwell is awarded her M.D. by the Geneva Medical College of Geneva, New York, becoming the United States' first female doctor.
1870 – In Montana, U.S. cavalrymen kill 173 Native Americans, mostly women and children, in what becomes known as the Marias Massacre.

SEE FROM MARCH 28

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

The Secondary Education Examination (SEE) for this year will begin on March 28. A meeting of the National Examination Board (NEB) on Sunday decided to conduct SEE from March 28 to April 9, informed NEB chairperson Mahashram Sharma.

He said although the initial plan was to conduct the examinations in the first week of Chaitra (the 12th month in Nepali Calendar), the NEB adjusted the schedule to begin the exam at the end of the second week of Chaitra due to the festival of Fagu.

STRIKE KILLS HEZBOLLAH FIGHTER, CIVILIAN IN LEBANON

AP
Sidon, Lebanon, Jan. 22

An Israeli airstrike hit two vehicles near a Lebanese army checkpoint in south Lebanon on Sunday, killing a Hezbollah member in one car and a woman in the other and wounding several other people, Lebanese state media and health officials reported.

The strike appeared to be part of a shift in Israeli strategy toward targeted killings in Lebanon after more than three months of near-daily clashes with Hezbollah militants on the border against the backdrop of the war in Gaza.

Hezbollah announced that one of its members, identified as Fadel Shaar, had been killed in the strike in the town of Kafra. Several hours later, Lebanon's National News Agency reported that a civilian woman wounded in the strike, Samar al-Sayyed Mohammed, had died of her injuries.

Local civil defense and hospital officials said several others were wounded. Video from the scene showed a passenger sedan in flames next to a small truck stopped in the middle of the road.

The Israeli military did not comment on the strike. Since the outbreak of the Israel-Hamas war on Oct. 7, Hezbollah forces have engaged in near-daily clashes with Israeli troops along the border.

While the clashes had previously been limited mainly to a narrow strip within a few kilometers (miles) from the border, Israel in recent weeks appears to have moved to a strategy of targeted killings of figures from Hezbollah and allied groups, sometimes hitting in areas relatively far from the border, as was the case in Sunday's strike.



PHOTO: RSS

Farmers milking female sheep at a farm Dhawalagiri Rural Municipality in Myagdi district.

S. Arabia for Palestinian state

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 22

Saudi Arabia's top diplomat said the kingdom will not normalize relations with Israel or contribute to Gaza's reconstruction without a credible path to a Palestinian state — a nonstarter for Israel's government.

Prince Faisal bin Farhan's remarks in an interview with CNN broadcast late Sunday were some of the most direct yet from Saudi officials.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu — who faces mounting domestic pressure over the plight of Israeli hostages, including an angry protest inside a parliamentary committee meeting on Monday — has rejected Palestinian statehood and described plans for open-ended military control over Gaza.

The dispute over Gaza's future — as the war rages with no end in sight — pits Israel against its top ally, the United States, as well as much of the international community, and poses a major obstacle to any plans for postwar governance or reconstruction of the impoverished coastal enclave that is home to 2.3 million Palestinians.

Before the Oct. 7 Hamas attack on Israel that triggered the war, the U.S. had been trying to broker a landmark agreement in which Saudi Arabia would normalize relations with Israel in exchange for U.S. security guarantees, aid in establishing a civilian nuclear program and progress toward resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

In September, Netanyahu had said Israel was on "the cusp" of such a deal.

In the interview with "CNN's Fareed Zakaria GPS," the host asked: "Are you saying unequivocally that if there is not a credible and irreversible path to a Palestinian state, there will not be normalization of relations between Saudi Arabia and Israel?"

"That's the only way we're going to get a benefit," Prince Faisal replied. "So, yes."

Earlier in the interview, when asked if oil-rich Saudi Arabia would finance reconstruction in Gaza — where Israel's offensive has caused unprecedented destruction — Prince Faisal gave a similar answer.

"As long as we're able to find a pathway to a solution ... then we can talk about anything," he said. "But if we are just resetting to the status quo before Oct. 7, in a way that sets us up for another round of this, as we have seen in the past, we're not interested in that conversation."

The Palestinians seek a state that would include Gaza, the Israeli-occupied West Bank and annexed east Jerusalem, territories Israel captured in the 1967 Mideast war.

Israel views all of Jerusalem as its capital and the West Bank as the historical and biblical heartland of the Jewish people. It has built scores of settlements across both territories that are home to hundreds of thousands of Jewish settlers. The last of several rounds of peace talks broke down nearly 15 years ago.

At a meeting about the war on Monday, European Union foreign ministers said the creation of a Palestinian state was the only way to achieve peace and expressed concern about Netanyahu's rejection of the idea.

The current war between Israel and Hamas — the fifth and by far deadliest — began when Palestinian militants broke through Israel's defenses and rampaged through several nearby communities, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking around 250 people hostage.

Israel's offensive has killed at least 25,295 Palestinians in Gaza and wounded more than 60,000, according to the Health Ministry in the Hamas-ruled territory. The ministry does not distinguish between civilians and combatants but says around two-thirds of those killed were women and children.

Medics reported heavy fighting in the southern city of Khan Younis, saying dozens of dead and wounded people were brought to the city's already overwhelmed Nasser Hospital. Families could be seen fleeing south, to areas already packed with hundreds of thousands of displaced people.

The Israeli military says it has killed around 9,000 militants, without providing evidence, and blames the high civilian death toll on Hamas because it positions fighters, tunnels and other militant infrastructure in dense residential areas.

Some 85% of Gaza's people have fled their homes, seeking elusive shelter in the south as Israel continues to strike all parts of the besieged enclave.

PM directs to resolve conflict between CTEVT and Nursing Council

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has emphasised the need to address challenges in the medical education and nursing sectors through an all-inclusive approach. The Prime Minister made these remarks during a high-level discussion on issues relating to the nursing sector at the Prime Minister's Office in Singha Durbar.

During the discussion, Prime Minister Prachanda acknowledged the existing conflict between the jurisdictions of the Nursing Council and the Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training (CTEVT) in the context of nursing education. "We need to resolve the conflicting jurisdiction between the Nursing (Council) and the CTEVT when discussing nursing education," said PM Prachanda.

The PM disclosed plans for an upcoming meeting of the Medical Education Commission to tackle the issues in both medical education and nursing.

"We will convene the meeting of the Medical Education Commission soon. Comprehensive discussions are required to identify challenges in the health and nursing sectors. Following the Commission's meeting, let us establish a study committee to systematically address these concerns. It's essential to involve the National Planning Commission in this process," said Prachanda.

While recognising the necessity for legal amendments to address issues, the Prime Minister underscored the importance of demonstrating readiness to implement existing laws.

"We must proactively address legal challenges through the amendment process. Our commitment to implementing provisions outlined in the law should be unwavering. Let's focus on achievable actions within our current resource framework and establish an implementation schedule," he said.

Deputy Prime Ministers Purna Bahadur Khadka and Narayan Kaji Shrestha, Ashok Kumar Rai, Minister of Education, Science and Technology, Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal, Suresh Adhikari, Secretary at the Ministry of Education, Shukla Khanal, Registrar of the Nursing Council, among others were present in the meeting.

Stay order issued on director's appointment

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

The High Court Patan has issued an interim order asking the Pashupati Area Development Trust (PADT), Governing Council to refrain from implementing its decision to appoint Laxmi Pun as the Executive Director of the PADT.

A division bench comprising judges Rhishiram Dawadi and Shyam Kumar Bhattarai on Sunday issued the verdict in this regard, disallowing the newly appointed PADT Executive Director from carrying out official duties.

Upon initial scrutiny, it was found that the academic qualifications and job experiences mentioned in Pun's bio-data do not match the criteria specified in the rules.

Hence, the court has withheld the appointment until the matter is finally sorted out by the court.

Pun was appointed to the post by a decision of the PADT Governing Council on December 20, 2023.

It may be noted that one Bharat Marasini on January 11 moved the court against the appointment of Pun as the PADT executive director. In the writ, it has been claimed that Pun failed to meet the academic qualifications and criteria for the appointment on the post.

The criteria for the appointment require a Master's degree in any subject from a certified academic institution and a minimum of 15 years of experience as a second-class officer in the government service or an organized institution registered as per the existing law or an international organization. In the case of a Bachelor's degree, the minimum required job experience is at least 20 years.

Nepalgunj extends winter vacation by two days

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Jan, 22

Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitican City has extended the winter holidays by two days, even though the given winter vacation ended on Saturday.

Cold wave has gripped Banke district making life difficult for the denizens. Owing to shivering cold, various municipalities of the district have extended the winter vacation as the children, elderly and people from impoverished communities are hard hit by the ongoing cold waves.

Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitican City has extended the winter holidays by two days, even though the given winter vacation ended on Saturday. Moreover, schools in Kohalpur Municipality, Khajura, Janaki, Duduwa, Raptisonari and Baijanath Rural Municipalities have also extended winter vacation.

Shrawan Kumar Pokharel, Chief District Officer and coordinator of the District Disaster Management Committee said that the works were being carried out to protect the citizens from the cold wave as per the Cold Wave Emergency Plan 2080 prepared by the committee.

The local governments have made arrangements to make collective fire in their respective areas as the temperature has dropped to a significant level affecting the citizens.

The Chief District Officer Pokhrel said, "We have extended the winter vacation for two days as children are being infected with cold-related ailments and we have distributed warm clothes to the needy citizens."

The movement of people too has dropped owing to the cold waves. Similarly, the mobility of service seekers has also decreased in government offices.

Most of the morning and evening flights from Nepalgunj have been affected in the past few days because of cold waves, fog and low visibility.

According to the Civil Aviation Office, the flights from Nepalgunj to Humla, Bajura, Rara of Mugu, Dolpa and Jumla have been irregular in the morning and flights to Kathmandu have been delayed owing to fog and low visibility.

Iran is 'directly involved' in Yemen Houthi rebel ship attacks: US commander

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 22

Iran is "very directly involved" in ship attacks that Yemen's Houthi rebels have carried out during Israel's war against Hamas, the U.S. Navy's top Mideast commander told The Associated Press on Monday.

Vice Adm. Brad Cooper, the head of the Navy's 5th Fleet, stopped short of saying Tehran directed individual attacks by the Houthis in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden.

However, Cooper acknowledged that attacks associated with Iran have expanded from previously threatening just the Persian Gulf and its Strait of Hormuz into waters across the wider Middle East.

"Clearly, the Houthi actions, probably in terms of their attacks on merchant shipping, are the most significant that we've seen in two generations,"he told the AP in a telephone interview. "The facts simply are that they're attacking the international community; thus, the international response I think you've seen."

Iran's mission to the United Nations did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Cooper's remarks. Houthi leadership in Yemen's capital, Sanaa, could not be immediately reached.



FILE PHOTO: AP

U.S. Navy Vice Adm. Brad Cooper, who heads the Navy's Bahrain-based 5th Fleet, speaks at an event at the International Defense Exhibition and Conference in Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, Feb. 21, 2023.

Since November, the Iranian-backed Houthis have launched at least 34 attacks on shipping through the waterways leading up to Egypt's Suez Canal, a vital route for energy and cargo coming from Asia and the Middle East onward to Europe.

The Houthis, a Shiite rebel group that's held Sanaa since 2014 and been at war with a Saudi-led coalition backing Yemen's exiled government since 2015, link their attacks to the Israel-Hamas war. However, the ships they've targeted increasingly have tenuous links to Israel — or none at all.

In recent days, the U.S. has launched seven rounds of airstrikes on Houthi military sites, targeting air bases under the rebels' control and suspected missile launch sites. The tempo of Houthi attacks on shipping appears to have slowed for the time being as the U.S. and its allies have increased their naval patrols in the region.

However, risks for the global economy remain as many ships continue to bypass that route for a longer trip around Africa's southern tip. That's meant lower revenue for Egypt through the Suez Canal, a vital source of hard currency for the country's troubled economy, as well as higher costs for shipping that could push up global inflation.

PM: Stop extending...

were waiting to receive their licence cards, he alerted the Department of Transport Management (DoTM) to provide them with their licences immediately.

Expressing his dissatisfaction, he said, "I am being blamed for the work you are not doing. The youth see the government at fault and criticise the Prime Minister. They do not understand that the DoTM has caused the delays, not the Prime Minister, and frankly, they do not need to understand. It is their right to receive a licence. Please do not be careless about this."

At the meeting, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha instructed the agencies to take the Prime Minister's instructions seriously and use technology to make their services quicker and more efficient.

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka, Minister for Foreign Affairs NP Saud, Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, secretaries of various ministries and heads of concerned departments were present at the meeting.

Construction of Highway in Koshi faces...

construction companies. However, the source is not guaranteed.

Datta said that the Koshi section of the Madan Bhandari Highway stretches from Sardu Khola in Sunsari to Patapur in Jhapa for a length of 127.8 km. Out of this, 32 km from the Kamal Khola to Sahadatsthal and 6 km from Chatara to Sardu Khola have not been contracted.

Out of the 95.8 km contracted, only 19.5 km of the road has been paved. Seven separate contracts have been signed for road construction. According to the agreement, the blacktopping work of the project was to be completed by now.

Khakurel said that the contract period of the project will be extended due to the legal complications in removing trees from the road area and the lack of budget assurance.

On the other hand, the divisional forest officers in Jhapa, Morang, Sunsari and Ilam districts have cited legal challenges hindering tree removal, primarily arising from the double standards of the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure.

Ramlakhan Thakur, Divisional Officer representing Morang, said that the initial communication called for the removal of trees within a 10x10 metre radius from the centre point of the road.

As per instructions, the Forest Office initiated the work. However, during the preparation and submission of the report, it was said that trees within a 15x15 metre radius from the centre point of the road should be removed. Again, the district officials adjusted their preparations accordingly.

Following this, the project decided to reverse the work, citing the potential significant damage to the forest.

Thakur said that the work came to a standstill upon receiving information that varying numbers of trees needed removal periodically. In Morang, out of the total 35.4 kilometres of road, 7 kilometres of road passes through the forest area.

Despite marking the trees which need to be cut down, no substantial progress has been made. Similarly, 7 km of road in Sunsari, 3 km in Jhapa and 6 km Ilam falls in the forest area.

The Wheel on display



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

A collective art exhibition titled 'The Wheel,' featuring artworks by renowned Nepali artists, kicked off at the Nepal Art Council on Monday.

Organised by the Cycle Culture Community, the art exhibition showcased six dozen artworks aimed at promoting cycle culture in Nepal.

The Cycle Culture Community concluded a workshop on 'Cycle Culture in Painting' at the Nepal Tourism Board in October last year.

Robin Koirala, the art coordinator of the workshop and exhibition, stated that the display of cycle culture-friendly artworks by nationally and internationally acclaimed artists, generated through the workshop, sets a new example in the Nepali context.

The exhibited paintings span abstract, tangible, semi-realistic, realistic, and surrealistic styles.

Notable artists such as Shashi Bikram Shah, Govind Dangol, Krishna Manandhar, Bijay Thapa, Jit Bahadur Rayamajhi, Ratankumar Rai, Mukesh Malla, Rakesh Shrestha, Sunita Rana, Chiten Sherpa, Sarita Dangol, along with past presidents of Lalitkala Pragya Pratishthan, Kiran Manandhar, Ragini Upadhyay and KK Karmacharya participated in the workshop.

Koirala informed that 32 artists took part in creating a historic collection of 72 artworks.

In collaboration with the Cycle Culture Community, which has been spearheading various intellectual-artistic programmes for the establishment of cycle culture-friendly infrastructure and civilization in Nepal, the painting exhibition has begun.

Tara Lal Shrestha, the programme coordinator of the painting workshop and exhibition, emphasised that without any special donors or foreign aid they are conducting a creative campaign through mutual support, cooperation, and financial contributions.

He stated that the painting workshop and exhibition were organised in response to the realisation of the need for a creative campaign in connection with art, literature, and philosophy to foster the development and expansion of cycle culture.

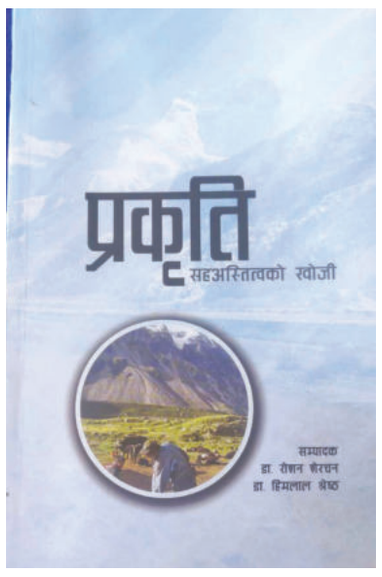




The exhibition began from Monday will continue till January 28 at the Nepal Art Council, Babarmahal, Kathmandu.

Foresters come up with 'Prakriti'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22



Publication House Indigo Ink in association with Nepal Forestry Technologists Association has come up Prakriti: Sahaastitwako Khoji (Nature: The Search Of Co-existence). A collection of promissory notes in Nepali by 27 foresters and ecology activists, the book has recently hit the bookstalls all over the country.

Edited by Dr. Roshan Sherchan and Dr. Himlal Shrestha, the book appeals to save nature for the long life of the earth. "The anthropocentric world view has damaged the ecology. That's why we should stand for eco-centric world view," the editors have written in the blurb of the book.

The writeups centre on miscellaneous parts of nature conservation including the management of the forests, the study of forestry, ecological crisis, indigenous knowledge, wildlife conservation and research, climate change, gender issue, inclusion, sustainable development and so on. The writers have written their feelings while they studied and worked in the field of nature conservation.

In his writeup, Dr. Rishi Bastakoti writes that he had done community-based service in Nepal and continued it in the USA as well. Dr. Roshan Sherchan, who is also a famous essayist, in his article 'Pinne Alias Peanut' professes a deep love for his dog while Kamal Jung Kuwar stresses making the ecology conservation field free of corruption for sustainable ecology.

Other writers including Kamal Thapa, Kamala Rupakheti, Kalpana Ghimire, Dr. Krishna Hari Gautam, Gayatri Karki, Govinda Kafle, Dr. Chandra Giri, Dr. Jagadish Chandra Baral, Dharti Chandra Yatri, Pashupati Koirala, Dr. Pushpaa KC Bhandari, Bharat Man Shrestha, Dr. Meera Tripathi, Mukti Gautam, Ramesh Kumar Thapa, Ramesh Prabhat, Dr. Raj Babu Pahadi, Dr. Rajesh Rai, Bijayraj Paudel, Bijay Hitan, Bishnu Prasad Acharya, Subhash Chandra Devkota, Dr. Syambhu Man Amatya and Dr. Himlal Shrestha also have printed their distinct footprints while they worked for the conservation of the ecology.

Meanwhile, a panel discussion was organised on the book at K And K International College in the capital. Journalist Ramesh Bhusal, authors Chet Nath Kanel 'Harit' and Bina Thing expressed their views that the articles would contribute to the eco-friendly world. "I find the articles a form of good eco-literature," Harit said at the discussion moderated by Milan Budhathoki and Balika Maden.

Dr. Himlal Shrestha, co-editor of the book, addressed the queries raised in the discussion.

The discussion was organised by the Association of Nepal Science Journalists.

'Mean Girls' fetches $11.7M in second weekend to stay No. 1 at box office

AP
New York, Jan. 22



On a quiet weekend in movie theaters, "Mean Girls" repeated atop the box office with $11.7 million in ticket sales, according to studio estimates Sunday, while a handful of awards contenders sought to make an impact ahead of Oscar nominations Tuesday.

With a dearth of new releases in cinemas, Paramount Pictures' Tina Fey-scripted musical "Mean Girls" pushed its two-week total past $50 million, along with $16.2 million internationally. So far, it's outpacing the tally for the 2004 original "Mean Girls."

Only one new film debuted in wide release: "I.S.S.," a modestly budgeted sci-fi thriller starring Ariana DeBose. The film, which speculates what would happen aboard the International Space Station if war broke out between the U.S. and Russia, debuted with $3 million on 2,518 screens for Bleecker Street.

Expectations weren't high for "I.S.S.," which drew only so-so reviews and was lightly marketed. Audiences also didn't like it, giving the film a "C-" CinemaScore.

But even for January, historically a low ebb for moviegoing, it was a sparsely attended weekend, with paltry options on the big screen. The top 10 films collectively accounted for just $51.3 million in box office, according to Comscore.

With a similarly thin release schedule on deck for next weekend, it could be the start of a chastening trend for Hollywood in 2024. Due to production delays caused by last year's strikes, there are significant holes throughout this year's movie calendar.

The Jason Statham thriller "The Beekeeper," from Amazon MGM Studios, remained in second place, grossing $8.5 million in its second weekend to bring its total to $31.1 million.

Warner Bros. "Wonka," six weeks into its smash run in theaters, was third, with $6.4 million in ticket sales. It's taken in $187.2 million domestically.

Also continuing to leg out was Sony Pictures' "Anyone But You." The rom-com starring Sydney Sweeney and Glen Powell, crossed $100 million globally in its fifth week of release. It's the highest grossing R-rated romantic comedy — a genre that has largely migrated to streaming platforms — since 2016's "Bridget Jones's Baby." Domestically, it came in fourth with $5.4 million.

Bollywood celebrities attend Ram temple consecration in Ayodhya

AGENCIES
New Delhi, Jan. 22



Many prominent Indian cinema personalities, including Amitabh Bachchan, Rajinikanth, Alia Bhatt, and Ranbir Kapoor, attended the consecration ceremony at the Ram temple in Uttar Pradesh's Ayodhya on Monday.

Actor couple Vicky Kaushal and Katrina Kaif, filmmakers Rohit Shetty, Rajkumar Hirani, actors Ayushmann Khurrana, Madhuri Dixit Nene along with her husband Sriram Nene and producer Mahaveer Jain also made an appearance as part of the contingent from the Indian film industry at the ceremony.

Amitabh Bachchan left for Ayodhya from Mumbai on Monday along with his son, actor Abhishek Bachchan.

At the temple premises, the screen icon was spotted interacting with Arun Govil, the actor who became a household name with the portrayal of Lord Ram in the 1987 TV serial "Ramayan". The Bachchans also met BJP MP Ravi Shankar Prasad and industrialist Anil Ambani at the venue.

Earlier in the day, Chiranjeevi was photographed disembarking from a chartered plane at the Ayodhya airport. He was accompanied by his wife Surekha and son, "RRR" star Ram Charan.

Actor Kangana Ranaut, who reached Ayodhya on Saturday, previously hailed the ceremony as a "divine experience".

After the completion of the rituals, several personalities including Sarod maestro Amjad Ali Khan, actor Ajay Devgn, and singer Shreya Ghoshal extended their wishes on social media.

Hema Malini, Rajinikanth, Pawan Kalyan, Madhur Bhandarkar, Subhash Ghai, Shefali Shah, Vipul Shah, Randeep Hooda, Lin Laishram, Aadinath Mangeshkar, Anu Malik and Sonu Nigam reached in the temple town on Sunday.

Actors Akshay Kumar and Tiger Shroff, who are currently shooting for their upcoming film 'Bade Miyan Chote Miyan', had wished fans ahead of the ceremony through a video message on social media.

Anupam Kher, who reached Ayodhya on Sunday, said regardless of religion, the country has come together today.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You're putting down roots. You may be someone who normally has no desire to be tied to anyone or anyplace, but when something really tugs on your heart, you might discover that you genuinely want to settle down.

TAURUS: The support that you're currently receiving -- or not receiving -- matters. Have you been the one providing a lot of support recently, to the people who are close to you, your job, or your community?

GEMINI: Material security might currently be of the utmost importance to you. This could come in the form of unexpected bills, a job search, or the task of managing someone else's financial future.

CANCER: You're becoming more responsible. Regardless of your typical attitude toward accountability, now is the time to stand firm and commit your energies to improving life for yourself.

LEO: You might be ready to understand spiritual matters that you didn't grasp before. You may have recently experienced a confusing time, and it's likely that this is weighing on you in an unfamiliarly heavy way.

VIRGO: You're creating order in chaos. Other people may not know how to work with unruly circumstances, but you have the power to take the craziness and put it all in order faster than anyone else could.

LIBRA: Being an authority figure isn't a bad thing. Whether this means that you're in charge of someone less experienced than you, you're imposing limits on someone, or you're teaching a subject that you know a lot about.

SCORPIO: You might be trying to create structures that will elevate you and others. However, those who don't understand your vision could be less than supportive. You've got a vision of the future that's better than the one we're in now!

SAGITTARIUS: Valuable investments may not be solely financial at the moment. You may be seeking out avenues to success, perhaps through spending time with someone fascinating.

CAPRICORN: Someone in your life can help you with skills you might not currently share with them. You may not understand much about a subject that entices you, and it would be easier to learn from a friend.

AQUARIUS: Consistent effort is even more valuable than usual. While you may enjoy running wild with experimentation, you've probably noticed that some areas of life require consistency for success.

PISCES: Self-expression is paramount at the moment. Perhaps you were afraid to voice your needs in the past due to the people or pressures around you, but you may now feel emboldened to say what's on your mind.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Police, Bagmati, Madhesh bag fourth win at PM Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 22

Nepal Police Club, Bagmati Province, and Madhesh Province secured their fourth win in the Prime Minister Cup Men's One Day National Cricket Tournament on Monday.

At Siddhartha Cricket Stadium in Bhairahawa, Nepal Police Club defeated APF Club by 58 runs. The Police's fourth consecutive win sent them to the top with eight points. APF, on the other hand, is in the sixth position with four points after suffering their second defeat.

APF was bowled out for 87 runs in 34 overs while chasing the victory target of 146 runs set by the Police. Spinner Lalit Rajbanshi took five wickets, Rashid Khan took two, and Sagar Dhakal claimed one wicket while restraining APF.

Sandeep Jora (25 not out), Amar Rautela (23), and Prajwal Shahi (13) were the only APF batsmen to score in double digits. Earlier, after being put to bat first, Police scored 145 runs for the loss of all wickets in 41 overs. Opener Dilip Nath scored the highest 44 runs for the Police. Arjun Saud (31), Shankar Rana (22), and Captain Dipendra Singh Airee (15) chipped in with double digits for Police.

Bhuvan Karki took three wickets, and Amarsingh Rautela took two, while captain Rohit Kumar Paudel and Shyam Dhakal took one wicket each in APF's bowling.

Similarly, Bagmati Province defeated Karnali Province by seven wickets at Upper Mulpani Cricket Ground. It was Bagmati's fourth consecutive victory, earning them eight points from six games. Karnali has four points from five games.

Chasing the target of 79 runs set by Karnali, Bagmati won in 13 overs, losing three wickets. Ishaan Pandey hit 40 and Ravin Joshi scored 16 not out for Bagmati. Diwan Pun took all three wickets for Karnali.

Karnali, who elected to bat, scored 78 runs in 24.2 overs, losing all wickets. Apart from Arjun Gharti scoring 23 runs and Nischal Rawal scoring 13 runs for Karnali, other batsmen could not score runs in double figures. Rijan Dhakal took five wickets for Bagmati.

At TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Madhesh defeated Sudurpaschim Pradesh by 80 runs. Madhesh claimed their fourth victory in their sixth match at the PM Cup, collecting six points. Sudurpaschim, which conceded its first defeat, is in fourth place with three points from four games.

Sudurpaschim was reduced to 239 runs in 44.5 overs with the loss of all wickets while pursuing the huge target of 320 runs presented by Madhesh for victory. Earlier, Madhesh, who elected to bat, scored 319 runs for the loss of nine wickets in the scheduled 50 overs.

Mayan Yadav was the highest scorer for Madhesh, with 115 runs in 128 balls. Similarly, Pawan Sarraf contributed 70 runs in 63 balls, while Anil Shah garnered 69 runs in 70 balls.

For Sudurpaschim, Sher Malla took four wickets, and Bikash Agri took two wickets.

In Sudurpaschim's run chase, Naren Bhatt smashed a century with 121 runs off 122 balls. Narayan Joshi (26), Kiran Thagunna (20), Khadak Bohora (14), Naren Saud (18), and Gajendra Bohara (12) scored double figures on the board for Sudurpaschim.

For Madhesh, Rajesh Yadav and Pradeep Paswan took three wickets each.



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN
Mayan Yadav of Madesh Province raises his bat after scoring a century against Sudurpaschim Province during Men's PM Cup cricket match held at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Monday.

RAMPANT GIRONA KEEP LIGA LEAD

AFP
Barcelona, Jan. 22

Artem Dovbyk struck a hat-trick inside seven minutes as minnows Girona powered back to the top of La Liga with a thumping 5-1 win over Sevilla on Sunday.

After Real Madrid scraped a controversial 3-2 win over bottom side Almeria and a treble by Ferran Torres helped Barca win 4-2 at Real Betis, Girona demonstrated their title credentials.

The Catalan club, in the top flight for only the fourth season in their history, are shock challengers for the Spanish title and lead second-place Madrid by a point, having played one extra game.

Madrid's victory over winless Almeria, which took them temporarily top before Girona played, was steeped in drama and controversy. Dani Carvajal rammed home the winner in the 99th minute to settle a wild and hugely entertaining clash at the Santiago Bernabeu where Madrid had trailed 2-0.

Almeria took a two-goal lead through Largie Ramazani's 38th minute strike and a screamer from Edgar Gonzalez. Madrid battled back to triumph as Jude Bellingham converted a penalty and Vinicius Junior used his upper arm to divert home an equaliser, before Carvajal's last-gasp winner.

Barcelona, third, let a two-goal lead slip against Betis but recovered to stay in the title race. Torres scored twice to put Barca two ahead but they surrendered their lead as former Real Madrid playmaker Isco struck a brace of his own.

At Girona's Montilivi stadium, struggling Sevilla, 17th, and just a point above the relegation zone, took a surprise lead through Isaac Romero.

However Dovbyk's rapid treble between the 13th and 19th minutes saw Michel Sanchez's sparkling side take full control.

Ukrainian compatriot Viktor Tsygankov got in on the action early in the second half and substitute Cristhian Stuani rounded off the rout.



Alcaraz sets up quarterfinal against Zverev

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 22

Carlos Alcaraz completed a Grand Slam set by reaching the Australian Open quarterfinals for the first time, setting up a showdown against Olympic champion Alexander Zverev.

All four quarterfinalists from the top half of the women's draw are also into the last eight at Melbourne Park for the first time, with No. 12-seeded Zheng Qinwen the highest-ranked player in the group.

Zheng matched her career-best run — she reached the U.S. Open quarterfinals last year — by breezing to a 6-0, 6-3 win in under an hour against Oceane Dodin in the last night match.

She'll next play Anna Kalinskaya, who beat No. 26 Jasmine Paolini 6-4, 6-2. In 13 previous majors, Kalinskaya had never got past the second round.

Zheng received a surprise visit from 2014 Australian Open winner Li Na, China's first major winner, after the third round and took some advice: "Focus on the moment. Li Na said, 'Just play, don't think too much. Keep it simple.'"

Alcaraz, the 20-year-old Wimbledon champion, missed the season-opening major in 2023 because of injury. But he's more than making up for lost time.

The No. 2-seeded Alcaraz beat Miomir Kecmanovic 6-4, 6-4, 6-0 in less than two hours Monday to open the night session on Rod Laver Arena.

He has dropped just one set en route to the last eight. Zverev is there for the third time but is coming off some long five-set wins, including a four-hour, 7-5, 3-6, 6-3, 4-6, 7-6 (3) fourth-round victory over No. 19 Cameron Norrie.

It was the 32nd five-set match so far at Melbourne Park, a tournament record in the Open era.

No. 3 Daniil Medvedev, a two-time Australian Open runner-up, beat No. 69-ranked Nuno Borges 6-3, 7-6 (4), 5-7, 6-1 and will next face No. 9 Hubert Hurkacz, who ended the run of French wild-card entry Arthur Cazaux 7-6 (6), 7-6 (3), 6-4.

While the highly-ranked players continue to advance in the men's draw, the seeded players keep toppling out on the women's side. And that has opened opportunities for Dayana Yastremska and Linda Noskova to advance to the quarterfinals of a Grand Slam for the first time.

Yastremska beat the 18th-seeded Victoria Azarenka 7-6 (6), 6-4, a two-time Australian Open champion, and No. 23-seeded Elina Svitolina had to retire after hurting her back when she was trailing Noskova 3-0.

SNIPPETS

Saudis toil into Asian Cup last 16

Doha (AFP): Roberto Mancini's Saudi Arabia reached the Asian Cup knockout rounds on Sunday with a laboured 2-0 win over a Kyrgyzstan side who played most of the second half with nine men. Also in Group F, an unadventurous Thailand held Oman 0-0 to inch towards the last 16 in Qatar. Mancini's men are ranked 56 in the world to Kyrgyzstan's 98 but they made hard work of their depleted opponents before joining holders Qatar, Iran, Iraq and Australia in the next round. The Saudis, who came back to claim a last-gasp 2-1 victory over Oman in their opening game, have six points from two matches.

Liverpool goes 5 points clear

London (AP): Liverpool appears to have the squad depth to last the pace in the Premier League title race. Shorn of Mohamed Salah — away at the Africa Cup of Nations — as well as creative midfielder Dominik Szoboszlai and most of their first-choice defense, the league leaders comfortably stymied the threat of in-form Bournemouth in a 4-0 away win on Sunday. Liverpool regained its five-point lead over a trio of chasers — including defending champion Manchester City, which has a game in hand — and extended its unbeaten run in the league to 14 matches.

The Premier League has never had a goal scored later than the penalty converted by Sheffield United's Oli McBurnie in the 13th minute of stoppage time in the team's 2-2 draw with West Ham. The competition's latest goal on record was previously a penalty, too, scored by Dirk Kuyt for Liverpool against Arsenal in 2011. That was timed at 101 minutes and 48 seconds, and McBurnie's was scored 19 seconds later.

Juventus moves top of Serie A

Rome (AFP): Juventus won 3-0 at Lecce on Sunday to move to the top of Serie A and bring down the curtain on a weekend dominated by racist abuse aimed at Milan goalkeeper Mike Maignan in Udine. Juventus struck three times in the second half in Lecce to give coach Max Allegri his 300th Serie A victory.

They stretched their league unbeaten run to 16 matches, winning a fifth straight and moving to the top of the table for the first time since they ended the 2019-20 season as champions. AC Milan are seven points back in third after they cane from behind to win 3-2 at Udinese on Saturday in a game halted when Maignan left the field in the first half following persistent racist abuse.

French gloom clouds Paris Olympics, six months from start

AFP
Paris, Jan. 22



Political bickering, ongoing grumbling about ticket prices and disruption to everyday life are souring the mood in the build-up to the Paris Olympics this July -- something organisers blame on typical French pessimism.

Several recent announcements have led to a spike in negative publicity for the sporting mega-event which will start in just six months and draw a television audience of billions.

Many Parisians were dismayed in December by news that transport ticket prices are set to double for the duration of the event and that they should work from home to free up seats on busy metros and buses.

The unveiling of planned security measures led to claims some parts of the city would face Covid-style lockdowns, while controversy erupted about the environmental impact of a judges' tower at the surfing venue in French Polynesia.

On top of it all, Paris's Socialist mayor Anne Hidalgo and President Emmanuel Macron's centrist government fell out publicly after Hidalgo claimed that planned Paris transport upgrades would "not be ready".

"There have been a succession of issues that have been badly handled from a communication point of view," said Philippe Moreau Chevrolet, a lecturer in communication at Sciences Po university in Paris and the founder of the MCBG Conseil PR agency.

"Instead of getting people behind the Games, they have created mistrust," he told AFP.

France's association of hoteliers and restaurants owners issued an unusual statement earlier this month, condemning French politicians for their "anxiety-inducing" announcements around the Games and urging them to come together.

"In general, we would strongly urge all of our public authorities, collectively and with solidarity, to speak positively and responsibly," the statement added.

Other recent complaints centre on the construction work that snares traffic daily around the capital, while resentment lingers over the handling of ticket sales last year that saw many locals priced out.

Paris will see "the most expensive ticket prices in an athletics arena that we have witnessed at an Olympic Games," said World Athletics president Sebastian Coe in December. Coe, who oversaw the 2012 London Olympics, added he was worried the families of some athletes would be unable to attend.

> Performance anxiety is also natural for every Olympic Games host as it prepares to showcase the best of itself to the rest of the planet.

Olympics bashing?

Paris 2024 organisers remain confident that sights such as beach volleyball in front of the Eiffel Tower, swimming in the river Seine, or the marathon through the capital's fabled streets will lift spirits once the flame is light on July 26.

They make a distinction between the often noisy and attention-seeking media and political debate and wider public opinion.

A survey by the Odoxa group for RTL radio in November suggested that 65 percent of French people were in favour of the Games -- a fall of 11 points in two years but still a large majority with positive views.

In the Paris region, slightly more than half of people were in favour.

Organisers also point to the orderly preparations, as well as their budget restraint in comparison with other modern editions. Most of the sporting infrastructure is finished. The athletes' village is almost ready to be furnished. Crucial metro and train line extensions will be ready in time, they insist.

"What if everything went ok?" asked a headline in the left-wing Liberation newspaper at the start of the year.

"France is ready for the Olympics... but given the country's gloomy mood and its unpopular leaders, there is no sign of popular fervour," it added.

Tony Estanguet, the head of the Paris organising committee, has criticised "Olympics bashing" in the media and the former canoeing champion despaired of his compatriots' tendency to look on the downside.

"We like to look at what is not going well, focus on things that are out of place, concentrate on our weak spots, whereas some countries like to play up their qualities and strengths," he told France Inter radio this month.

'Not unusual'

Jennifer Minner, an academic at US-based Cornell University who studies major international events, says grouchy locals are a frequent feature of the build-up.

"I've found that pessimism is not unusual immediately prior to the staging of a 'mega-event', especially when the realities of hosting become more apparent," she told AFP.

Performance anxiety is also natural for every Olympic Games host as it prepares to showcase the best of itself to the rest of the planet.

Surveys show French people are most nervous about a security problem, particularly at the spectacular opening ceremony being planned on the river Seine.

"It's possible that once the Games are underway, if everything goes well, people get into the spirit of the Games," added Moreau Chevrolet.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:37 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	14.4	3.0	0.0
Dipayal	23.0	3.1	0.0
Dhangadi	11.3	9.0	0.0
Birendranagar	21.5	3.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.5	8.8	0.0
Jumla	15.4	-4.8	0.0
Ghorahi	18.5	8.2	0.0
Pokhara	19.6	5.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	18.2	7.5	0.0
Simara	19.0	9.6	0.0
Kathmandu	17.5	3.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.5	5.3	0.0
Taplejung	15.3	3.0	0.0
Dhankuta	21.0	6.2	0.0
Biratnagar	18.6	11.2	0.0
Jomsom	9.1	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	20.4	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	4.0	0.0*
Janakpur	21.8	10.4	0.0*
Jiri	13.9	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 23, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.61	Rs. 133.21
Euro	1	Rs. 144.33	Rs. 144.99
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.51	Rs. 169.27
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.65	Rs. 153.34
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.37	Rs. 87.77
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.79	Rs. 99.24
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.87	Rs. 99.31
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.96	Rs. 9.00
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.37	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.74
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.06	Rs. 28.18
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.90	Rs. 9.94
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.76
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.35	Rs. 19.44
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.92	Rs. 432.87
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.80	Rs. 353.39

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54